A FREE GUIDE FROM LEADERPACT

How leadership teams really work

10 chapters on purpose, membership, meetings, trust and conflict, each with the research it rests on.

LeaderPact · www.leaderpact.com · Edition of 18 October 2026

About this guide

This guide brings together the articles published at www.leaderpact.com. Each chapter answers one question a leadership team asks.

Every chapter opens with its answer and the points to take away. Its figures draw the argument, and its sources are listed at the end.

The sources were checked on 13 October 2026. The articles online are kept up to date, so read them there for the latest version.

Contents

PART 1 · WHERE TO START

1. Leadership team effectiveness: what makes a leadership team effective?
2. How to assess a leadership team
3. The five dysfunctions of a team: what does the research say?

PART 2 · PURPOSE, TASKS AND MEMBERSHIP

4. What is the purpose of a leadership team?
5. How do you write a leadership team charter?
6. How big should a leadership team be?

PART 3 · MEETINGS AND DECISIONS

7. Leadership team meeting agenda: how to build one that works

PART 4 · HOW THE TEAM WORKS TOGETHER

8. Psychological safety in leadership teams
9. How do you build trust in a leadership team?
10. Task conflict and relationship conflict: when disagreement helps

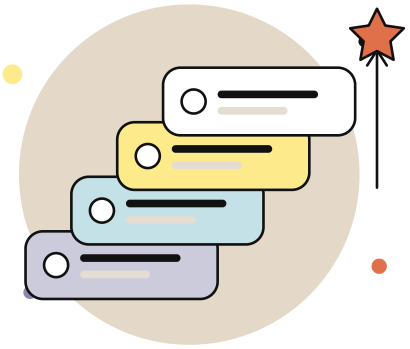
PART 1

Where to start

What makes a leadership team effective, and how to see where yours stands.

CHAPTER 1

Leadership team effectiveness: what makes a leadership team effective?



Leadership team effectiveness is how well a leadership team serves the organisation, stays able to work together and helps its members grow. Research puts the conditions first: a real team, a clear purpose, work that needs everyone and the right members. Then come focused meetings and disagreement about the work. Trust and psychological safety grow from both.

IN SHORT

- Leadership team effectiveness rests first on conditions: a real team, a clear purpose, work that needs everyone, the right members and support.
- In a study of eight top management groups, a clear goal for each agenda item and focused discussion went with effectiveness.
- Psychological safety, trust and cohesion matter, and they build up from how the team is set up and how it works.
- Judge effectiveness by direction, alignment and commitment, by the team's ability to keep working together, and by members' growth.
- Many senior groups are not real teams. Decide which issues truly need the whole team, and handle the rest elsewhere.

What is leadership team effectiveness?

Leadership team effectiveness is how well a leadership team serves the organisation, stays able to work together and helps its members grow. These are Hackman's three tests of any team, applied to the team at the top (Haas and Mortensen, 2016). By 2006, team research already spanned more than fifty years and thousands of studies (Kozlowski and Ilgen, 2006). Reviews describe a chain: inputs, then the processes and states that carry their effect, then outcomes (Mathieu et al., 2008).

It helps to read a leadership team in four layers: conditions, processes, states and outcomes.

1

Conditions

How the team is set up: membership, purpose, tasks, size and support.

2

Processes

How it works, mostly in meetings: goals, focus, dialogue and decisions.

3

States

What builds up between members over time: safety, trust and cohesion.

4

Outcomes

What the team produces, and what it leaves behind.

Source: Mathieu et al. (2008)

Layer	What it covers	Research to start with
Conditions	A real team, a clear purpose, shared tasks, the right members, support	Hackman (2002); Wageman and colleagues (2008)
Processes	Meeting preparation, item goals, focus, dialogue, task conflict, learning	Bang and colleagues (2010); Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock (2012)
States	Psychological safety, trust, cohesion and shared norms	Edmondson (1999); De Jong, Dirks and Gillespie (2016)
Outcomes	Direction, alignment and commitment; working well together; members' growth	Drath and colleagues (2008); Haas and Mortensen (2016)

What does an effective leadership team deliver?

Hackman proposed three tests for any team (Haas and Mortensen, 2016). First, does its output satisfy the people who receive it? Second, does the way it works keep it able to work well together? Third, do its members learn and develop through being part of it?



Source: Haas and Mortensen (2016)

For a leadership team, the people who receive its work are the rest of the organisation. Drath and colleagues argue that leadership shows itself in three outcomes for a group: direction, alignment and commitment (Drath et al., 2008). Direction is shared agreement on what the group is trying to achieve. Alignment is work that is coordinated. Commitment is members' willingness to make the success of the whole a priority, not only their own success.

Put together, these give a leadership team three questions to ask itself. Does the organisation get clear direction, aligned work and commitment from us? Are we still able to work well together? Are we, as individuals, getting better at leading?

A question for your team

If each of the people who report to us described our direction in one sentence, how many different sentences would we hear?

Why is a leadership team harder to make effective than other teams?

Katzenbach argued that even in well-run companies, the group at the top seldom works as a real team (Katzenbach, 1997). He gave several reasons. A meaningful collective purpose is hard to define at the top, and goals tend to be broad. Members are often chosen for their position rather than for the skills a shared task needs.

Executives are also used to being accountable for their own units, and mutual accountability can feel foreign. A group run by a single leader is often faster, and it fits the hierarchy. Katzenbach did not conclude that top teams are pointless. His advice was to tell team work from other work, and to handle each in its own way.

Later research points the same way. Wageman, Nunes, Burruss and Hackman studied more than 120 senior teams around the world (Wageman et al., 2008; Coutu, 2009). They describe executives who put their own functions ahead of the team's shared work. In an interview

about that research, Hackman said that almost every team believed its membership was clear. Yet when the researchers asked members to describe the team, fewer than 10 per cent agreed on its membership (Coutu, 2009).

Both accounts point to a double role. Each member leads a unit and is judged on it. The leadership team asks them to put the whole organisation first, with only part of their time (Katzenbach, 1997).

What conditions does an effective leadership team need?

Hackman's work on teams names five conditions (Hackman, 2002). They are a real team, a compelling direction, an enabling structure, a supportive organisation and expert coaching. For senior teams, Wageman and colleagues treat three as essential: a real team, a compelling purpose and the right people. Structure, support and coaching then help the team make the most of them (Wageman et al., 2008).

- **A real team.** Members know who is on the team and who is not. Hackman warned that a very large senior team may be worse than no team at all (Coutu, 2009). His example was one holding all the chief executive's direct reports.
- **A clear purpose.** The team needs a purpose of its own, not the sum of its members' jobs. Start from the purpose of a leadership team and the issues that need everyone.
- **Tasks that need the whole team.** Katzenbach's test is a collective work product: a result that draws on members' different skills, which none could produce alone (Katzenbach, 1997).
- **The right size and members.** Members should bring the skills the shared work needs, not only a senior title. Hackman's rule of thumb was no double digits (Coutu, 2009); see leadership team size.
- **Information and support.** The team needs data, time and help for its shared work, and coaching aimed at the team as a whole. Hackman reported that coaching individual executives did little to help senior teams perform better (Coutu, 2009).

A rule of thumb

If an agenda item could be settled by one member and the chief executive, it does not need the whole team. Keep the team's time for the issues only the team can solve.

How does an effective leadership team work together?

Most of a leadership team's shared work happens in meetings, so that is where its processes show. One study combined members' ratings with observers' data from eight top management groups and 56 agenda items (Bang et al., 2010). Goal clarity and focused communication were both linked to higher team effectiveness.

The same study found that flagging an unclear goal helped. Calling out a drifting discussion did not help performance, and it went with poorer relationships.

A broader study videotaped 92 regular team meetings (Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012). Teams with more problem-solving talk and action planning were more satisfied with their meetings, and better meetings went with higher team productivity. Criticising and complaining showed negative links that were stronger than the positive ones. For a practical format, see leadership team meeting agenda.

56

agenda items in eight top management groups, where clear goals went with effectiveness

Source: Bang et al. (2010)

92

videotaped team meetings, where better meetings went with higher productivity

Source: Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock (2012)

Meetings also need room for people to speak. Bang interviewed 21 executives from seven top teams about why they stayed silent when a meeting lost its way (Bang, 2012). Their silence rested mainly on a belief that speaking up would be seen as negative and bring unwelcome consequences.

Disagree about the work, not about each other

A meta-analysis of 116 studies found that relationship conflict was consistently linked to poorer group outcomes (de Wit et al., 2012). Task conflict was not strongly negative overall, and its link with performance was more positive in top management teams. The detail is in task conflict and relationship conflict.

Act as one team, and keep learning

Researchers call the first of these behavioural integration: how far a top team engages in mutual and collective interaction. A study of 402 firms found that the chief executive, the team and the firm each played a part (Simsek et al., 2005).

Learning is the other habit. In a study of 51 work teams, learning behaviour carried the link between psychological safety and team performance (Edmondson, 1999). Support from the organisation and coaching by the team leader also shaped outcomes.

What role do psychological safety, trust and cohesion play?

These are states, not actions. Shared properties of a team emerge from how members interact, and from selection, socialisation and leadership (Kozlowski and Klein, 2000). A team cannot simply decide to have them. It can shape the conditions and meetings they grow from.

Psychological safety is a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking (Edmondson, 1999). In Edmondson's study it went with more learning behaviour, which in turn went with better performance. See psychological safety in leadership teams.

Trust has a solid record too. Across 112 studies of 7,763 teams, trust among members was positively related to team performance (De Jong et al., 2016). This held even after allowing for past performance. The strength of the link depended on factors such as how interdependent the team's tasks were. More is in how to build trust in a leadership team.

Cohesion matters as well, with a twist. Across studies, it related more strongly to performance measured as behaviour than as outcomes (Beal et al., 2003). The link was also stronger where work flowed intensively between members. For a leadership team whose members mostly work apart, that is worth noting.

How do leadership team effectiveness models compare?

Several models describe what makes a team at the top effective. They differ in where they start: the team's set-up, its behaviour or its results.

Model	What it says matters	Use it to	The evidence
Hackman and Wageman: team conditions	A real team, a compelling direction and the right people; then structure, support and team coaching	Design the team before you work on behaviour	More than 120 senior teams (Coutu, 2009); a survey of the conditions tested on 321 teams (Wageman, Hackman and Lehman, 2005)
Katzenbach: real team or single-leader group	Real teams need a collective work product and mutual accountability; otherwise a single leader is often faster	Decide which work needs the whole team	A practitioner's argument, with company cases (Katzenbach, 1997)
Lencioni: five dysfunctions	Trust at the base, then open conflict, commitment, accountability and attention to collective results	Give the team a shared language for behaviour	Written as a fable, not as research (Lencioni, 2002); see five dysfunctions of a team
Drath and colleagues: direction, alignment, commitment	Leadership shows in three outcomes: shared direction, coordinated work and commitment to the whole	Judge what the organisation gets from the team	A theoretical framework from leadership research (Drath et al., 2008)
Input-process-outcome	Inputs shape processes and team states, which shape outcomes over time	Locate a problem: set-up, ways of working or states	The organising frame of reviews of team research (Mathieu et al., 2008)

Haas and Mortensen add a fourth condition, a shared mindset, to counter “us and them” thinking (Haas and Mortensen, 2016).

What are the signs of an ineffective leadership team?

Most signs show in meetings and in what the organisation hears. Treat each as a question to explore, not a verdict.

- **Members name different people when asked who is on the team.** Hackman found unclear membership common at the top (Coutu, 2009).
- **Members defend their own units first,** ahead of the team's shared work (Wageman et al., 2008).
- **Agenda items arrive without a stated goal,** and discussion drifts (Bang et al., 2010).
- **People stay silent when a meeting loses its way,** fearing it will look negative (Bang, 2012).

- **Disagreement turns personal,** which goes with poorer group outcomes (de Wit et al., 2012).
- **Units hear different priorities from different members,** a sign that direction and alignment are missing (Drath et al., 2008).

How do you measure leadership team effectiveness?

Ask every member the same short questions about the team, anonymously, across all four layers. Read both the average and how far members agree. Ask those who receive the team's work too: Hackman's first test is theirs to judge (Haas and Mortensen, 2016).

Haas and Mortensen suggest a light check every few months, with deeper reviews when problems arise (Haas and Mortensen, 2016). Methods, example questions and ways to keep answers anonymous are in how to assess a leadership team.

How do you build a high-performing leadership team?

Build a high-performing leadership team layer by layer, in order. The steps below turn the research into practice; adapt them to your team.

1. **Decide where you need a team**
   List the decisions and work that need everyone, and send the rest to individuals or smaller groups.
2. **Settle who is on it**
   Name the members, and check that every member would give the same list.
3. **Agree the purpose together**
   A leadership team charter is one way to record purpose, members and ways of working.
4. **Give every meeting item a stated goal**
   Say whether it is for information, discussion or decision, and keep the discussion on that goal.
5. **Make disagreement about the work normal**
   Ask for the strongest case against a proposal before you decide.
6. **Review how you work**
   Spend ten minutes at the end of a meeting on what helped and what got in the way.
7. **Measure, then talk**
   A short anonymous survey of every member gives a starting point for the talk that follows.

Frequently asked questions about leadership team effectiveness

Is leadership team effectiveness different from team effectiveness?

The tests are the same: output, the ability to keep working together and members' growth (Haas and Mortensen, 2016). The setting differs. A leadership team's output lands on the whole organisation, and each member also answers for a unit (Katzenbach, 1997).

Does leadership team effectiveness affect results?

The evidence is indirect. Across 112 studies, trust among members went with team performance (De Jong et al., 2016). In 92 team meetings, constructive interaction was related to organisational success 2.5 years later (Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012). Neither looked only at leadership teams, and both show links rather than causes.

What can you do this month?

Pick one layer and test it in your next two meetings. Each of these takes minutes, and each tells you something.

- Ask each member, privately, to list who is on the leadership team. Compare the lists.
- Ask which three issues this quarter need all of you, and which issues do not.
- Give every agenda item a one-line goal and an owner, and check at the end whether you met it.
- Close one meeting by asking what each member held back, and what would have made it easier to say.

A question to close with

What do we do together that none of us could do alone, and how much of our meeting time goes on it?

SOURCES

1. Kozlowski, S. W. J., & Ilgen, D. R. (2006). Enhancing the effectiveness of work groups and teams. Psychological Science in the Public Interest, 7(3), 77–124.
2. Mathieu, J. E., Maynard, M. T., Rapp, T., & Gilson, L. (2008). Team effectiveness 1997–2007: A review of recent advancements and a glimpse into the future. Journal of Management, 34(3), 410–476.
3. Hackman, J. R. (2002). Leading teams: Setting the stage for great performances. Harvard Business School Press.
4. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.
5. Coutu, D. (2009). Why teams don't work (an interview with J. Richard Hackman). Harvard Business Review, 87(5), 98–105.
6. Haas, M., & Mortensen, M. (2016). The secrets of great teamwork. Harvard Business Review, 94(6), 70–76.
7. Katzenbach, J. R. (1997). The myth of the top management team. Harvard Business Review, 75(6), November–December 1997.

8. Drath, W. H., McCauley, C. D., Palus, C. J., Van Velsor, E., O'Connor, P. M. G., & McGuire, J. B. (2008). Direction, alignment, commitment: Toward a more integrative ontology of leadership. The Leadership Quarterly, 19(6), 635–653.
9. Bang, H., Fuglesang, S. L., Ovesen, M. R., & Eilertsen, D. E. (2010). Effectiveness in top management group meetings: The role of goal clarity, focused communication, and learning behavior. Scandinavian Journal of Psychology, 51(3), 253–261.
10. Kauffeld, S., & Lehmann-Willenbrock, N. (2012). Meetings matter: Effects of team meetings on team and organizational success. Small Group Research, 43(2), 130–158.
11. Bang, H. (2012). What prevents senior executives from commenting upon miscommunication in top management team meetings? Qualitative Research in Organizations and Management, 7(2), 189–208.
12. de Wit, F. R. C., Greer, L. L., & Jehn, K. A. (2012). The paradox of intragroup conflict: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 97(2), 360–390.
13. Simsek, Z., Veiga, J. F., Lubatkin, M. H., & Dino, R. N. (2005). Modeling the multilevel determinants of top management team behavioral integration. Academy of Management Journal, 48(1), 69–84.
14. Edmondson, A. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383.
15. Kozlowski, S. W. J., & Klein, K. J. (2000). A multilevel approach to theory and research in organizations: Contextual, temporal, and emergent processes. In K. J. Klein & S. W. J. Kozlowski (Eds.), Multilevel theory, research, and methods in organizations (pp. 3–90). Jossey-Bass.
16. De Jong, B. A., Dirks, K. T., & Gillespie, N. (2016). Trust and team performance: A meta-analysis of main effects, moderators, and covariates. Journal of Applied Psychology, 101(8), 1134–1150.
17. Beal, D. J., Cohen, R. R., Burke, M. J., & McLendon, C. L. (2003). Cohesion and performance in groups: A meta-analytic clarification of construct relations. Journal of Applied Psychology, 88(6), 989–1004.
18. Lencioni, P. (2002). The five dysfunctions of a team: A leadership fable. Jossey-Bass.
19. Wageman, R., Hackman, J. R., & Lehman, E. (2005). Team Diagnostic Survey: Development of an instrument. The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science, 41(4), 373–398.

CHAPTER 2

How to assess a leadership team



Ask every member the same short set of questions about the team, anonymously, then read both the average and how far members agree. Discuss the result together before anyone acts on it. Add a look at how your meetings actually run, because a survey shows views, not behaviour.

IN SHORT

- Measure the team as a whole, with statements about “we” and “this team”, never about individual members.
- Cover four layers: the team's conditions, its processes, its states and its outcomes.
- Read the level and the agreement. A middling average can hide a team split in two.
- Protect anonymity. Set a minimum number of answers, and in a small team never show a lowest score, a distribution or a subgroup.
- Show nothing until the round closes, interpret the results together, and agree one change to act on.

What should you measure in a leadership team?

Measure the team, not its members. The aim is a picture of how the team is set up and how it works, so that you can change both.

A useful frame has four layers, set out in leadership team effectiveness. One well-documented instrument, the Team Diagnostic Survey, was built on research about the conditions that foster team effectiveness (Wageman, Hackman and Lehman, 2005). It asks how well a team is structured, supported and led, and about members' work processes and reactions to the team.

Layer	What to ask about	An illustrative warning sign
Conditions	Membership, purpose, tasks that need the whole team, size, composition, information and support	Members give different answers about who is on the team
Processes	Meeting preparation, a goal for each item, focus, dialogue, how disagreement is handled, learning	Items arrive with no stated goal
States	Psychological safety, trust, cohesion and shared norms	People keep concerns to themselves in the meeting
Outcomes	Direction, alignment and commitment; the team's ability to keep working together; members' growth	Units hear different priorities from different members

Outcomes deserve a place even though they are hard to measure. Drath and colleagues describe direction, alignment and commitment as the outcomes of leadership in a group (Drath et al., 2008). Hackman's three tests add the team's ability to keep working together and its members' own development (Haas and Mortensen, 2016).

Which methods can you use to assess a leadership team?

Four methods are common, and each sees part of the picture. A survey is a practical starting point, and one other method adds depth.

Method	What it shows well	Watch out for
Member survey	Every member's view at once, with level and agreement, quickly	It shows views, not behaviour, and needs anonymity to be candid
Observing meetings	What actually happens: goals, focus, who speaks and how decisions are made	It needs a skilled observer, and one meeting may not be typical
Interviews	The reasons and examples behind the scores	Answers are not anonymous to the interviewer, and they take time
Outside stakeholders	How the team's output lands with those who receive it	They see results, not how the team works

Researchers use observation to study meetings closely. Bang and colleagues combined members' ratings with observers' data from top management group meetings (Bang et al., 2010). Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock coded 92 videotaped team meetings (Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012). Functional interaction, such as problem solving and

action planning, went with more satisfying meetings, and better meetings went with higher team productivity.

Stakeholders matter because the first of Hackman's tests is judged by the people who receive the team's work (Haas and Mortensen, 2016). Ask them about outcomes, such as how clear the direction they receive is. Do not ask them to rate individual members.

Popular models can start a useful conversation too. If your team uses one, such as the five dysfunctions of a team, check the research on each part first.

A rule of thumb

Start with a member survey for breadth. Then watch one or two real meetings to see whether behaviour matches the scores.

What are good leadership team effectiveness survey questions?

Good questions are about the team. In a referent-shift model, each member answers about the team as a whole rather than about themselves (Chan, 1998). Edmondson's measure of psychological safety, for example, asks about “this team” (Edmondson, 1999).

The usual rules of item writing apply too (Hinkin, 1998). Keep each statement short and simple, in words members use. Make each one address a single issue, because a double-barrelled item mixes two things and confuses people.

Hinkin also cites evidence that reliability rises up to five scale points and then levels off, and he suggests five-point agreement scales. Keep the set short as well, since short measures reduce bias from boredom and fatigue (Hinkin, 1998). For a full measure he suggests four to six items per construct; a quick pulse can use fewer.

Example questions

The statements below are examples written for this article, not items from any published instrument. Each is answered on a five-point scale from strongly disagree to strongly agree.

- Conditions: “It is clear who is a member of this team.”
- Conditions: “This team spends its time on issues that need all of us.”
- Processes: “Each item in our meetings has a clear goal.”
- Processes: “Our discussions stay on the issue at hand.”
- Processes: “When we disagree, the disagreement is about the work.”
- States: “On this team, it is safe to raise a concern about a decision.”
- States: “We can rely on each other to do what we agreed.”

- Outcomes: “The people who report to us hear the same priorities from each of us.”

Notice what each example does. It names one thing, it speaks of “we” or “this team”, and it describes something a member could see happen. None of them asks a member to judge a colleague.

A rule of thumb for wording

If a statement contains “and”, check whether it asks two questions. If it names a person or a role, rewrite it about the team.

Why does agreement matter as much as the average?

A team average only means something if members broadly agree. Multilevel researchers treat a property such as a team climate as shared only when members' views converge (Kozlowski and Klein, 2000). Before averaging, they check agreement within the group (LeBreton and Senter, 2008).

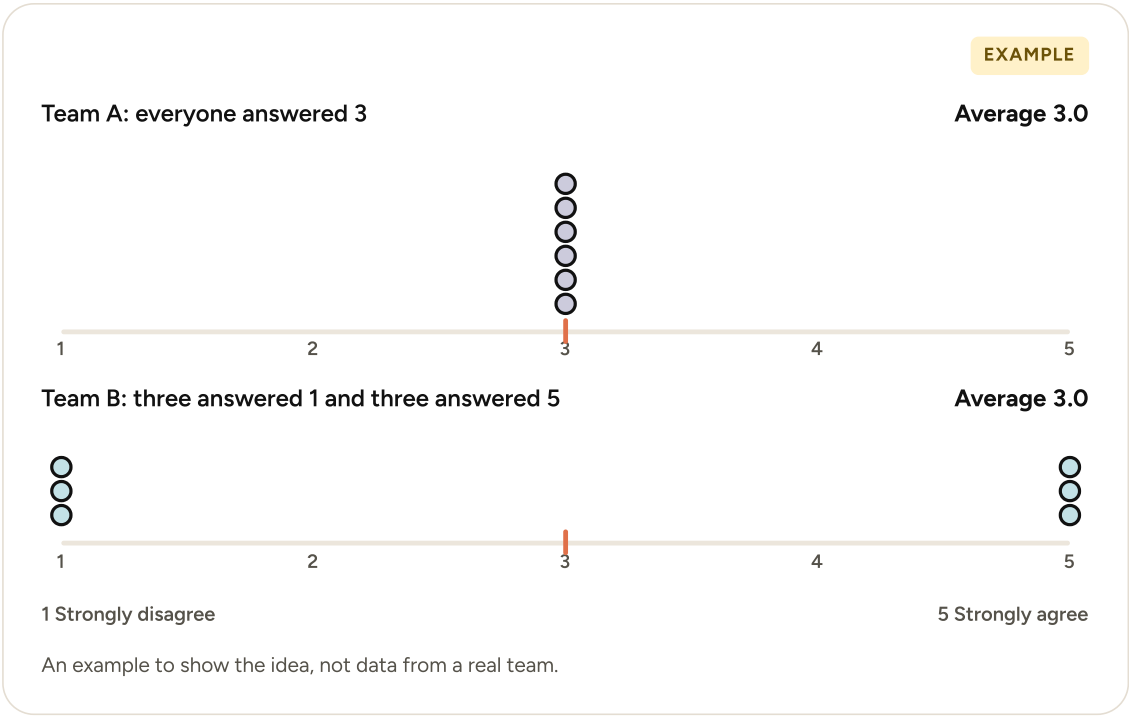
A common index is rwg (James, Demaree and Wolf, 1984). It compares how much members' answers vary with how much they would vary if people answered at random. A value near 1 means close agreement, and a value near 0 means no more agreement than chance (O'Neill, 2017).

LeBreton and Senter (2008) offered rough bands, from a lack of agreement below about 0.3 to very strong agreement above 0.9. O'Neill (2017) cautions against applying any single cut-off mechanically, including the popular 0.70. He also notes that with few raters, statistical tests of agreement are hard to pass.

The spread can be a finding in its own right. Chan's (1998) typology includes a dispersion model, in which the spread of members' views is itself the property of interest. Cole and colleagues argue that variance among members can add to what the mean tells you (Cole et al., 2011).

An example

Take a team of six that averages 3.0 on “Each item in our meetings has a clear goal”. Everyone may have answered 3. Or three may have answered 1, and three answered 5. The second team needs a different conversation.

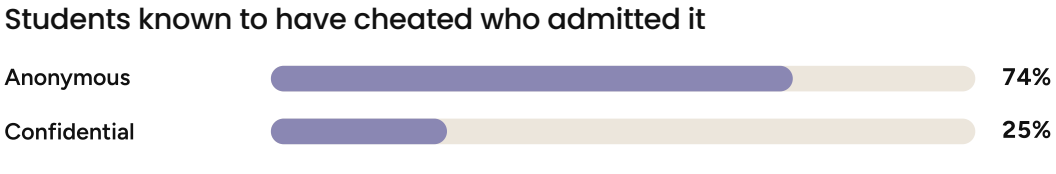


An example to show the idea, not data from a real team.

In practice, read three things. Is the level high or low? Do members agree? Where they do not, what might explain the split? In a team of four to eight, treat agreement as a prompt for discussion, not a verdict.

How do you keep a leadership team survey anonymous?

Anonymity matters because people say more when an answer cannot be traced to them. One study looked at students known to have cheated (Ong and Weiss, 2000). Under anonymity, 74 per cent admitted it, against 25 per cent under confidentiality. The setting was not a workplace, but it shows how much traceability can matter.



Source: Ong and Weiss (2000)

Senior people have their own reasons for caution. Executives in Bang's interviews thought flagging an unclear goal or a drifting discussion would be seen as negative and draw unwelcome consequences (Bang, 2012).

Removing names is not enough in a small group. Sweeney examined how released data can be re-identified, and proposed a rule called k-anonymity (Sweeney, 2002). Each person's data must be indistinguishable from that of at least k-1 others. For a team survey, that means a minimum number of answers before any result is shown.

In a team of four to eight, several common displays can point to one person:

- **The lowest or highest score.** If one person answered 1, the minimum is their answer, and colleagues often know who is unhappy.
- **A distribution.** In a small team, a bar showing one answer at the bottom is close to naming a dissenter.
- **Subgroups.** Splitting six people by role or location can leave groups of one or two.
- **Changes in membership.** If one person joins or leaves between rounds, the change in the average can help reveal their answer.
- **Early results.** Scores shown while answers are coming in let anyone who checks before and after a colleague answers see that answer.

A rule of thumb for anonymity

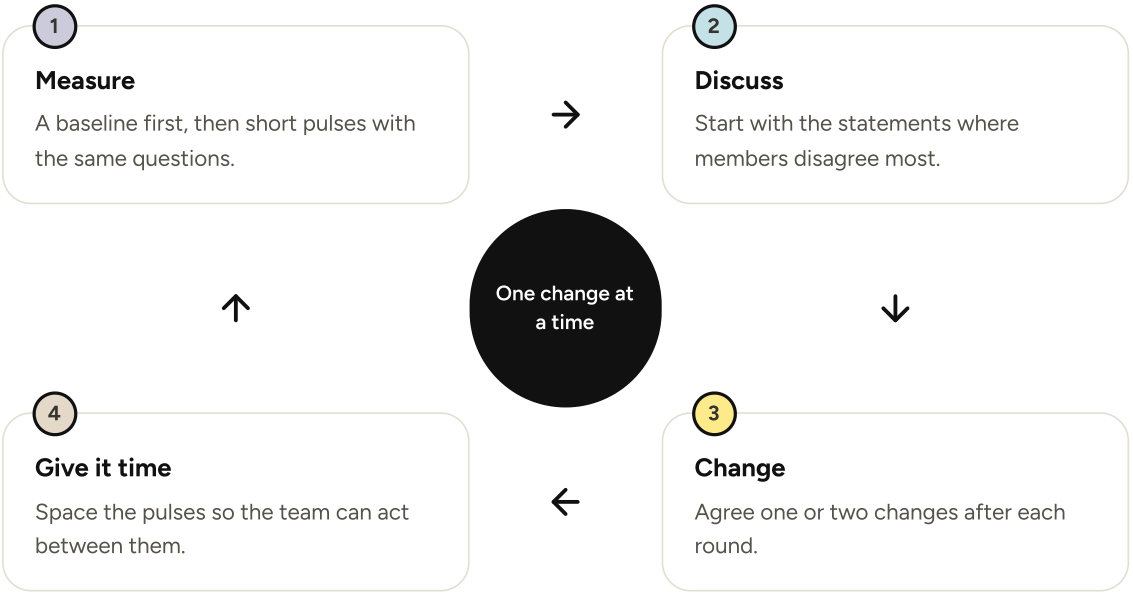
Decide the minimum number of answers before the survey opens, and never lower it to get a result. Show averages and a plain note on agreement, and nothing that points to a single answer.

How often should a leadership team be assessed?

Start with a baseline, then use short pulses. Haas and Mortensen suggest a quick check every few months, with deeper reviews when problems arise (Haas and Mortensen, 2016).

Teams change, and team research has moved to models that take account of time (Mathieu et al., 2008). A pulse after you change something tells you whether the change worked. Ask the same questions each time, so the answers can be compared.

Space the pulses so that the team has time to act between them. Measuring again before anything has changed adds little.



What mistakes should you avoid when assessing a leadership team?

- **Rating or ranking individuals.** A team assessment is about the team. Scores per member turn it into an appraisal of people, which is a different exercise with different risks.
- **Using results for performance evaluation.** If scores feed bonuses or reviews, members have a reason to answer strategically. Keep the results for the team's own development.
- **Showing results before everyone has had the chance to answer.** Early results can sway those still to answer, and they can expose individuals.
- **Leaving interpretation to the leader.** Bang's interviews suggest that executives may keep concerns to themselves (Bang, 2012). A leader reading the results alone may miss what they mean.
- **Measuring without acting.** Agree one or two changes after each round, and check them at the next pulse.

Results on safety and trust are easier to discuss with some groundwork. See psychological safety in leadership teams for ways to make that conversation easier.

What can you do this month?

You can run a simple assessment in a month with a short survey and one meeting. The steps below keep it anonymous and useful.

1. Choose eight to twelve statements across the four layers, each written about “we” or “this team”.
2. Agree the minimum number of answers, and what will be shown, before anyone answers.
3. Collect answers anonymously, and show nothing until the round closes.
4. Share each statement's average and a plain note on agreement, with no individual scores, lowest scores or subgroups.
5. Discuss the results in a meeting, starting with the statements where members disagree most.
6. Pick one change, and check it with a short pulse in two or three months.

A question for your team

Where do we see this team most differently, and what would each of us need to hear to understand why?

SOURCES

1. Wageman, R., Hackman, J. R., & Lehman, E. (2005). Team Diagnostic Survey: Development of an instrument. The Journal of Applied Behavioral Science, 41(4), 373–398.

2. Drath, W. H., McCauley, C. D., Palus, C. J., Van Velsor, E., O'Connor, P. M. G., & McGuire, J. B. (2008). Direction, alignment, commitment: Toward a more integrative ontology of leadership. The Leadership Quarterly, 19(6), 635–653.
3. Haas, M., & Mortensen, M. (2016). The secrets of great teamwork. Harvard Business Review, 94(6), 70–76.
4. Bang, H., Fuglesang, S. L., Ovesen, M. R., & Eilertsen, D. E. (2010). Effectiveness in top management group meetings: The role of goal clarity, focused communication, and learning behavior. Scandinavian Journal of Psychology, 51(3), 253–261.
5. Kauffeld, S., & Lehmann-Willenbrock, N. (2012). Meetings matter: Effects of team meetings on team and organizational success. Small Group Research, 43(2), 130–158.
6. Chan, D. (1998). Functional relations among constructs in the same content domain at different levels of analysis: A typology of composition models. Journal of Applied Psychology, 83(2), 234–246.
7. Edmondson, A. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383.
8. Hinkin, T. R. (1998). A brief tutorial on the development of measures for use in survey questionnaires. Organizational Research Methods, 1(1), 104–121.
9. Kozlowski, S. W. J., & Klein, K. J. (2000). A multilevel approach to theory and research in organizations: Contextual, temporal, and emergent processes. In K. J. Klein & S. W. J. Kozlowski (Eds.), Multilevel theory, research, and methods in organizations (pp. 3–90). Jossey-Bass.
10. LeBreton, J. M., & Senter, J. L. (2008). Answers to 20 questions about interrater reliability and interrater agreement. Organizational Research Methods, 11(4), 815–852.
11. James, L. R., Demaree, R. G., & Wolf, G. (1984). Estimating within-group interrater reliability with and without response bias. Journal of Applied Psychology, 69(1), 85–98.
12. O'Neill, T. A. (2017). An overview of interrater agreement on Likert scales for researchers and practitioners. Frontiers in Psychology, 8, article 777.
13. Cole, M. S., Bedeian, A. G., Hirschfeld, R. R., & Vogel, B. (2011). Dispersion-composition models in multilevel research: A data-analytic framework. Organizational Research Methods, 14(4), 718–734.
14. Ong, A. D., & Weiss, D. J. (2000). The impact of anonymity on responses to sensitive questions. Journal of Applied Social Psychology, 30(8), 1691–1708.
15. Bang, H. (2012). What prevents senior executives from commenting upon miscommunication in top management team meetings? Qualitative Research in Organizations and Management, 7(2), 189–208.
16. Sweeney, L. (2002). k-anonymity: A model for protecting privacy. International Journal of Uncertainty, Fuzziness and Knowledge-Based Systems, 10(5), 557–570.
17. Mathieu, J. E., Maynard, M. T., Rapp, T., & Gilson, L. (2008). Team effectiveness 1997–2007: A review of recent advancements and a glimpse into the future. Journal of Management, 34(3), 410–476.

CHAPTER 3

The five dysfunctions of a team: what does the research say?



The five dysfunctions of a team are absence of trust, fear of conflict, lack of commitment, avoidance of accountability and inattention to results. Patrick Lencioni stacks them in a pyramid, each resting on the one below, and research supports several of these ideas taken one by one. But the book presents the model as a fable rather than as research. So treat the pyramid's order as a useful frame, not an established finding.

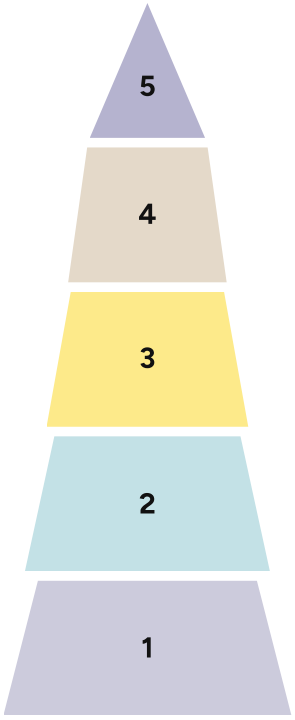
IN SHORT

- Lencioni's pyramid runs from trust at the base, through conflict, commitment and accountability, to results at the top.
- Research on trust and team performance, and on trust and conflict in top teams, fits the weight the model puts on trust.
- Research on conflict is more mixed than the model suggests: debate about the work goes with better results only under some conditions.
- Research-based models start from the team's conditions, such as a shared purpose, real shared work and the right members.
- Use the five dysfunctions as a shared language, and check the conditions underneath them.

What are the five dysfunctions of a team?

Patrick Lencioni set out the model in **The Five Dysfunctions of a Team: A Leadership Fable** (Lencioni, 2002). The book combines the story of a fictional chief executive and her struggling executive team with the model and practical advice for each part.

The five dysfunctions sit in a pyramid. In Lencioni's account each one grows out of the one beneath it, so a team works on them from the bottom up.



Inattention to results
When nobody is held to account, members put their needs, such as ego, career development or recognition, ahead of the team's collective goals.

Avoidance of accountability
Without clear commitments, peers hesitate to challenge each other on behaviour that hurts the team.

Lack of commitment
Without real debate, people do not buy into decisions, and it stays unclear what was agreed.

Fear of conflict
Without trust, people avoid open debate about ideas and keep an artificial harmony. Disagreement moves into side conversations.

Absence of trust
Members are unwilling to be vulnerable with one another. They hide their mistakes, their weaknesses and their need for help.

Source: Lencioni (2002)

What does Lencioni mean by vulnerability-based trust?

Trust sits at the base, and Lencioni means a particular kind of it. Members are willing to admit their mistakes, their weaknesses and their need for help to each other (Lencioni, 2002). He calls this vulnerability-based trust.

This is close to how researchers define trust. It is a willingness to be vulnerable to another person's actions, regardless of any ability to monitor or control them (Mayer et al., 1995). On this point the fable and the research use much the same idea.

Is the Lencioni model based on research?

The book presents the model as a fable rather than as research (Lencioni, 2002). Lencioni and his firm advise leaders and teams, and the book is written for practitioners: a story with a model attached.

That does not make it wrong. It means each part is a claim to set against other evidence, and the order of the pyramid is a frame to try. The sections below take the parts one at a time.

What does research say about trust in teams?

Across 112 studies covering 7,763 teams, trust within a team was positively related to team performance (De Jong et al., 2016). The link held after accounting for trust in the team leader and for the team's past performance.

The link also depended on the work. It was weaker where members could do their tasks alone, and mattered more where they depended on each other (De Jong et al., 2016).

These are correlations, so they show that trust and performance go together, not which causes which.

Research also widens the idea of trust. Colleagues judge each other on ability, benevolence and integrity (Mayer et al., 1995). Admitting weakness speaks to benevolence, but a team also needs to see members deliver and keep their word.

Is conflict good for a team?

Lencioni asks teams to welcome open debate about ideas and to stop protecting an artificial harmony. Research separates task conflict, about the work, from relationship conflict, about the people.

Relationship conflict is consistently bad news. Two meta-analyses found it negatively related to team performance and to members' satisfaction (De Dreu and Weingart, 2003; de Wit et al., 2012).

Task conflict is less simple. An earlier meta-analysis found it negatively related to team performance too, contrary to what textbooks had suggested (De Dreu and Weingart, 2003). A later one, of 116 studies, found no strong negative link overall (de Wit et al., 2012).

In that later analysis, task conflict was more positively related to performance in some settings (de Wit et al., 2012). They included top management teams, and teams where task conflict and relationship conflict were only weakly linked. It also looked better when performance meant decision quality or financial results.

Trust seems to decide which way debate goes. In a study of 70 top management teams, trust weakened the link between task conflict and relationship conflict (Simons and Peterson, 2000). That fits Lencioni's order: trust first, then open debate. For more on the difference, see task conflict and relationship conflict.

What does research say about commitment?

In the model, a team that avoids debate struggles to commit, because people have not bought in and ambiguity lingers (Lencioni, 2002). Research on fair process points the same way.

Korsgaard et al. (1995) ran an experiment with intact management teams. Members saw the process as fairer when their input was considered and they had some influence. That went with stronger commitment to the decision, attachment to the team and trust in its leader.

Research also separates what the model folds together. Drath et al. (2008) describe three outcomes of leadership: direction, or agreement on goals; alignment, or coordinated work; and commitment to the collective's success. Keeping them apart helps a team see which one is missing.

What does research say about accountability and results?

Lencioni wants peers to hold each other to account, rather than leave it all to the leader. Katzenbach and Smith (1993) made mutual accountability part of their definition of a team.

They also drew a line between a working group and a team. In a working group, members answer for their own results. A team also produces work together and answers for it together (Katzenbach and Smith, 1993).

Mutual accountability, they argued, cannot be ordered into being. It grows as a team works out its purpose, goals and approach together.

Results show a similar pattern. Senior executives often focus more on their own roles than on the top team's shared work (Wageman et al., 2008). Inattention to results can be ego, as the model says. It can also mean the team has no clear collective work to be accountable for.

How does each dysfunction compare with the research?

7,763

teams in 112 studies, where trust went with team performance

Source: De Jong et al. (2016)

116

studies in a meta-analysis that found no strong negative link between task conflict and performance

Source: de Wit et al. (2012)

70

top management teams, where trust weakened the link from task to relationship conflict

Source: Simons and Peterson (2000)

The dysfunction	What the model says	What research adds
Absence of trust	Members will not be vulnerable, so they hide mistakes and needs.	Trust goes with team performance across 112 studies. It rests on ability and integrity too, not only on openness.
Fear of conflict	Teams keep an artificial harmony and avoid debate about ideas.	Debate about the work goes with better results only under some conditions. Trust helps keep it from turning personal.
Lack of commitment	Without debate, people do not buy in and decisions stay vague.	A fair process, where input is considered, goes with stronger commitment. Commitment is distinct from agreeing on direction.
Avoidance of accountability	Peers do not challenge each other on behaviour that hurts the team.	Mutual accountability needs shared goals and work done together. It cannot be ordered.
Inattention to results	Members put status and ego ahead of collective goals.	Senior executives often favour their own roles. A clear shared purpose and real shared work come first.

How do research-based models of team effectiveness differ?

Research-based models tend to start further upstream, with the conditions a team works in. Hackman (2002) argued that how well a team is designed and supported matters more than the leader's personal style.

He named five conditions: a real team, a compelling direction, an enabling structure, a supportive organisational context and competent coaching (Hackman, 2002). Wageman et al. (2008) applied similar conditions to senior leadership teams, drawing on a study of more than 120 top teams.

Starting from behaviour

The five dysfunctions describe how members treat each other: openness, debate, buy-in, challenge and focus. They name symptoms a team can recognise quickly.

Starting from conditions

Research-based models ask first whether the team has a shared purpose, work only it can do and the right members. Behaviour then grows inside that frame.

The two views fit together. If a team has unclear membership or little shared work, Hackman's view suggests that work on behaviour alone may not hold. For the wider picture, see leadership team effectiveness.

Is there a five dysfunctions of a team assessment?

Yes. Commercial questionnaires built on the model exist, and they can give a team a shared language. Ask the same questions of them as of any team survey:

- What evidence does the publisher give that the scales measure what they claim to measure?
- Does it cover the team's conditions, such as purpose and membership, or only behaviour?
- How are answers kept anonymous in a team of six or eight people?
- Will the team see its own results and decide together what to do with them?

For methods and good questions, see how to assess a leadership team.

How can you use the model well?

- **Use it as a language, not a verdict.** The five words help a team name what it sees, without claiming to measure it.
- **Build trust through the work too.** Keeping commitments and sharing information give colleagues evidence of integrity and goodwill, not only of openness (Mayer et al., 1995).
- **Watch whether debate turns personal.** If arguments about the work start to feel like attacks, slow down and rebuild trust (Simons and Peterson, 2000).
- **Check the conditions first.** If members share little real work, settle the team's purpose before working on behaviour (Wageman et al., 2008).

Two articles go deeper on the base of the pyramid: how to build trust in a leadership team and psychological safety in leadership teams.

What can you do this month?

1. Ask each member which of the five dysfunctions they see most often in the team, with one example from the last month. Collect the answers anonymously if the team is new to this.
2. In your next meeting, pick one real decision. Before closing it, ask each person whether their view was heard, and what they are now committing to.
3. End the meeting by reading back who will do what by when. Open the next one by checking it.
4. Ask the team which of its goals no single member could reach alone. If the answer is none, start with the purpose of a leadership team before behaviour.

A question for your team

Think of our disagreements last quarter. Which stayed about the work, and which became personal? What made the difference?

SOURCES

1. Lencioni, P. (2002). The five dysfunctions of a team: A leadership fable. Jossey-Bass.
2. De Jong, B. A., Dirks, K. T., & Gillespie, N. (2016). Trust and team performance: A meta-analysis of main effects, moderators, and covariates. Journal of Applied Psychology, 101(8), 1134–1150.
3. Mayer, R. C., Davis, J. H., & Schoorman, F. D. (1995). An integrative model of organizational trust. Academy of Management Review, 20(3), 709–734.
4. De Dreu, C. K. W., & Weingart, L. R. (2003). Task versus relationship conflict, team performance, and team member satisfaction: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 88(4), 741–749.
5. de Wit, F. R. C., Greer, L. L., & Jehn, K. A. (2012). The paradox of intragroup conflict: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 97(2), 360–390.
6. Simons, T. L., & Peterson, R. S. (2000). Task conflict and relationship conflict in top management teams: The pivotal role of intragroup trust. Journal of Applied Psychology, 85(1), 102–111.
7. Korsgaard, M. A., Schweiger, D. M., & Sapienza, H. J. (1995). Building commitment, attachment, and trust in strategic decision-making teams: The role of procedural justice. Academy of Management Journal, 38(1), 60–84.
8. Drath, W. H., McCauley, C. D., Palus, C. J., Van Velsor, E., O'Connor, P. M. G., & McGuire, J. B. (2008). Direction, alignment, commitment: Toward a more integrative ontology of leadership. The Leadership Quarterly, 19(6), 635–653.
9. Katzenbach, J. R., & Smith, D. K. (1993). The discipline of teams. Harvard Business Review, 71(2), 111–120.
10. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.
11. Hackman, J. R. (2002). Leading teams: Setting the stage for great performances. Harvard Business School Press.

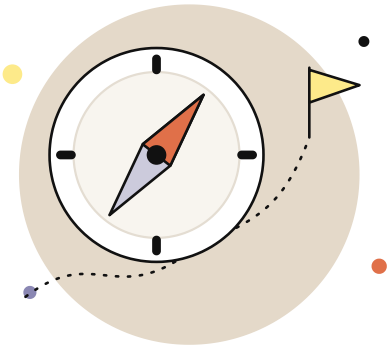
PART 2

Purpose, tasks and membership

The conditions that come first: why the team exists, which work needs all of it, and who belongs in it.

CHAPTER 4

What is the purpose of a leadership team?



A leadership team exists to do the work that only its members can do together. That means setting direction, making the decisions that cut across units, getting them carried out as one, leading change and developing leaders. Everything else belongs elsewhere: in a one-to-one, a smaller group or a written update.

IN SHORT

- A leadership team earns its time on work that needs several members at once: direction, cross-unit decisions, carrying them out, change and developing leaders.
- A group of direct reports is not a team by default. Much of what senior leaders do does not need a team at all.
- Sharing information, giving advice, coordinating and deciding are all legitimate uses of a leadership team. Trouble starts when nobody knows which one an item is.
- Test every agenda item: does it need the whole team? If not, move it to a one-to-one, a smaller group or a written update.
- Agree on purpose by having each member answer privately first, then compare the answers and settle on a few plain sentences.

What is a leadership team for?

A leadership team is for the work that needs several of its members at the same time. In their research-based model of effective management teams, Bang and Midelfart (2021) describe what such teams typically do.

They set overall goals, strategies and priorities, and they make vital decisions. They discuss issues, solve problems and give advice. And they make sure that units and processes are aligned and work well together. The same authors note that research suggests management teams are largely underused and less effective than they could be.

Drawn together, this research points to six jobs for a leadership team. The table shows what each one looks like when the team meets.

Purpose	What it looks like on the agenda
Set direction	Goals, strategy and priorities for the whole organisation, including what you will stop doing.
Make better decisions	Choices that affect several units, brought with options and a clear question for the team.
Get decisions carried out	Follow-up of earlier decisions: who does what by when, and what members tell their own units.
Work as one across units	Trade-offs between units, shared resources and hand-overs where one unit's work depends on another's.
Lead change	Major change efforts: progress, obstacles and what the team must do to keep them moving.
Develop leaders	Members asking each other for advice, succession, and how the team itself is working.

Notice what is missing. A round in which each member reports on their own unit fits none of the six. Nor does an item that concerns only one or two people around the table.

Is a leadership team a real team or just the leader's direct reports?

Often it is the second. Katzenbach (1997) argued that even in strong companies the group at the top seldom works as a real team. In his definition, a real team is a small group with complementary skills. Its members commit to a common purpose, shared goals and a way of working, and hold each other accountable.

Katzenbach also warned chief executives against treating their direct reports as a team simply because they report to the same person. Most of what senior leaders do together, he wrote, is not a real team opportunity. A working group with one leader is often faster for that work. Good leadership means telling the two kinds of work apart.

The research behind the book Senior Leadership Teams covered more than 120 top teams around the world (Wageman et al., 2008). The authors name three essentials: a real team with clear membership, a compelling direction and the right people. Membership was often fuzzy. When members were asked to describe their team, fewer than 10% agreed on who was on it (Coutu, 2009).

Hackman, one of the authors, added a warning about size. A very large senior team, say one with all the chief executive's direct reports, may be worse than no team (Coutu, 2009). For what the research says about numbers, see leadership team size.

What kinds of leadership team are there?

Ruth Wageman, drawing on her research on leadership teams, describes four kinds (Wageman, 2020). They run from the least to the most interdependent.



Source: Wageman (2020)

In Wageman's account, all four are legitimate uses of a leadership team. Trouble starts when nobody is clear which kind the team is being at a given moment. It also starts when it is unclear that a smaller group decides on behalf of the larger one.

She adds two observations worth testing in your own meetings. She found that most information-sharing teams mainly serve the chief executive, who gathers news that matters little to anyone else in the room. Consultation, by contrast, is underused. Members who advise each other become invested in each other's success.

Bang (2018) offers a similar list for Norwegian management teams. In his view, a management team is especially well suited to six roles:

- A governing body that takes overall responsibility for the organisation.
- An information body that keeps members well informed about what matters.
- A decision-making body that tests, anchors and makes well-founded decisions, and helps carry them out.

- A coordinating body for processes and tasks that cut across units.
- A body for change and development that finds what to improve and makes sure it happens.
- A source of advice and support, where members give and receive advice and back each other.

His question to a team is which of these it should become more of. Wageman (2020) makes a related point: problems arise when one group tries to do all four kinds of work at once.

Which issues need the whole leadership team?

An issue needs the whole team when members depend on each other to resolve it. Katzenbach (1997) put this in terms of collective work: something the members must produce together. Bang (2018) gives a similar test for the agenda. An item should be important, fit the team's purpose and need the whole team to be solved.

Four questions help you sort an item before it reaches the agenda:

- **Does it cross units?** If the decision changes what two or more units do, it probably belongs to the team.
- **Does it need knowledge spread around the table?** If one member already has all the facts, a one-to-one may do.
- **Will members have to carry it out together?** Items that need the same message in every unit belong in the room.
- **Is it worth the team's time?** A routine matter can go to a smaller group or a written update.

Time at the top is scarce, and strategy tends to lose out. Mankins (2004) reported that the senior executives of a typical company spent only about three hours a month in meetings on strategy.

Clarity about each item matters too. A study followed eight top management groups through 56 agenda items (Bang et al., 2010). Clear goals for an item went with more focused discussion and better team effectiveness. For how to build that into your meetings, see leadership team meeting agenda.

A rule of thumb

If an item concerns only you and one colleague, take it outside the meeting. If it only informs, send it in writing. Keep the room for work that needs everyone.

Why does the team need to agree on its purpose?

Because members often do not. An interview with the team researcher Richard Hackman summed up his findings bluntly. More often than not, members disagree about what their team is for (Coutu, 2009). Getting that agreement, in his view, is the leader's job.

A clear purpose also tells each member which role to play. Bang (2018) describes members as wearing two hats. One is responsibility for their own unit's results. The other is shared responsibility for the whole and for how the units work together. In the leadership team, he argues, the second hat comes first.

Bang and Midelfart (2021) treat a clear team purpose and appropriate team tasks as separate factors in their model. A team can agree on why it exists and still fill its meetings with the wrong items. Both need attention.

How do you agree on a leadership team's purpose?

Do it in one working session, with time to prepare. Bang (2018) suggests setting aside one to two hours of a meeting for two questions. What is the team for, and what should it produce? And which issues deserve more time, and which can leave the meeting?

1. **Answer alone first**
   Each member writes short answers before the meeting: what the team is for, which issues belong to it and which do not.
2. **Compare the answers**
   Put them side by side, without names if that helps people speak plainly. Look for where you differ, not only where you agree.
3. **Discuss the gaps**
   Spend most of the time on the differences. They show where members expect different things from the team.
4. **Agree on a few sentences**
   Write the purpose in two or three plain sentences, and list the kinds of issues that belong to the team.
5. **Test it for a quarter**
   Hold the next agendas against it, and adjust what does not work.

Why alone first? In brainstorming experiments, groups talking together produced fewer ideas than the same number of people working alone. The main cause was that members had to wait their turn to speak (Diehl and Stroebe, 1987). Private answers also put every member's view on the table before the discussion starts.

Then write the result down where the team will see it again. A leadership team charter holds the purpose together with the team's tasks, membership and working agreements.

A question for your team

What should this team produce that none of us could produce alone? Ask each member to write an answer before the meeting, then read the answers out together.

What can you do this month?

- Ask each member, privately, to list who is on the leadership team. Compare the lists before you discuss anything else.
- Sort the last three months of agenda items into the six purposes in the table above. Note what fits none of them.
- For each item on your next agenda, say which kind of team you need: informing, advising, coordinating or deciding.
- Move one standing information item into a written update, and give the time saved to strategy.
- Hold a session of one to two hours on what the team is for, with answers written alone first.

Purpose is the first condition, not the only one. For the others, see leadership team effectiveness.

SOURCES

1. Bang, H., & Midelfart, T. N. (2021). Effective management teams and organizational behavior: A research-based model for team development. Routledge.
2. Bang, H. (2018). 7 tips til hvordan dere kan utvikle dere til en mer effektiv og velfungerende ledergruppe [Presentation, 12 June 2018]. Partnerforum seminar for the Ministry of Health and Care Services, University of Oslo.
3. Bang, H., Fuglesang, S. L., Ovesen, M. R., & Eilertsen, D. E. (2010). Effectiveness in top management group meetings: The role of goal clarity, focused communication, and learning behavior. Scandinavian Journal of Psychology, 51(3), 253–261.
4. Coutu, D. (2009). Why teams don't work (an interview with J. Richard Hackman). Harvard Business Review, 87(5), 98–105.
5. Diehl, M., & Stroebe, W. (1987). Productivity loss in brainstorming groups: Toward the solution of a riddle. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 53(3), 497–509.
6. Katzenbach, J. R. (1997). The myth of the top management team. Harvard Business Review, 75(6), 82–91.
7. Mankins, M. C. (2004). Stop wasting valuable time. Harvard Business Review, 82(9), 58–65.
8. Wageman, R. (2020). Four kinds of leadership teams [Video lecture, recorded 2013]. The Business & Management Collection, Henry Stewart Talks.
9. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.

CHAPTER 5

How do you write a leadership team charter?



A leadership team charter is a short document the team writes together. It says why the team exists, which issues and decisions belong to it, who is in it and how members agree to work. It helps when the team writes it jointly and reviews it regularly. It does little when it sits in a drawer.

IN SHORT

- A charter covers purpose, team tasks and decision rights, membership, working agreements, the support the team needs, key stakeholders and a review date.
- In a business simulation with student teams, the best sustained performance came from teams with both a strong charter and a strong task plan.
- In a study of project teams, the high performers held participatory launch meetings rather than scripted ones.
- Write it together: each member drafts alone, the team compares and agrees, and the result fits on one page.
- Keep it alive by testing agenda items against it and reviewing it at least once or twice a year.

What is a leadership team charter?

A leadership team charter is a one-page agreement about how the team will work. It is not a mission statement for the organisation. It covers the team itself: what it is for, what it works on, who is in it and how members behave with each other.

Research on leadership team effectiveness explains why these topics matter. Hackman (2002) set out five conditions that make team success more likely. They are a real team, a clear and engaging direction, an enabling structure, a supportive organisational context and competent coaching. A later study of senior leadership teams named three essentials: a real team, a compelling direction and the right people (Wageman et al., 2008).

A charter puts the conditions the team can shape into words. Bang and Midelfart (2021) make a similar split in their model of effective management teams. They treat a clear team

purpose, appropriate team tasks, the right composition and supportive organisational systems as separate factors.

What should a leadership team charter include?

Seven parts cover what most leadership teams need to agree. Keep each one short; the whole charter should fit on a page.

Part	The question it answers	What to write
Purpose	Why does this team exist?	Two or three sentences on what the team must produce that no member could produce alone.
Team tasks and decision rights	Which issues come to the team, and what does it do with them?	A short list of issue types, each marked decide, coordinate, advise or inform.
Membership	Who is in the team?	Core members by name or role, and extended members who join for named items.
Working agreements	How do we work together?	Five to seven norms on preparing, disagreeing, deciding and speaking about decisions afterwards.
Support	What does the team need from the organisation?	The information it needs, how shared results count in rewards, and the training members need.
Key stakeholders	Who must we hear from and keep informed?	The board, owners, employee representatives or other groups, and how the team stays in touch with them.
Review date	When do we check it?	A date in the calendar, and a rule to review it whenever membership changes.

Team tasks and decision rights

This part decides what reaches the agenda. Wageman (2020) describes four legitimate uses of a leadership team: sharing information, giving advice, coordinating an initiative and making decisions together. She sees trouble when it is unclear which of these the team is doing. Marking each type of issue with one of the four makes that explicit.

Add who decides what. Some decisions belong to the team, some to one member after the team has advised, and some to the board. Writing this down saves the team from debating its own authority item by item.

Membership

Write the names down, even if it feels obvious. Hackman and colleagues studied more than 120 top teams. When they asked members to describe their team, fewer than 10% agreed on who was on it (Coutu, 2009).

One option is a core team that makes the team's decisions, with an extended group that joins for named items. For what research says about numbers, see leadership team size.

Working agreements

Norms form whether or not you write them. Feldman (1984) described several ways group norms develop. They include explicit statements by a leader or colleague, critical events in the group's history, what happens first, and habits carried over from elsewhere.

A written agreement is an explicit statement. Without one, early events and old habits are left to set the rules. Hackman made the same point about a team's start. The first time a group meets strongly shapes how it works for the rest of its life. That includes the norms members expect and enforce (Coutu, 2009).

Hackman warned that teams whose norms of conduct are vague or go unenforced always run into trouble (Coutu, 2009). So write norms as behaviour you can see. 'We read the papers before the meeting' can be checked. 'We respect each other' cannot.

Support

A team also depends on its context. Hackman argued that the organisation's reward, people and information systems must make teamwork possible (Coutu, 2009). Note what your team needs: data for its decisions, rewards that count shared results, and development for its members.

Do team charters actually help?

The evidence is encouraging, though it does not come from leadership teams. Mathieu and Rapp (2009) followed 32 teams of MBA students through a business strategy simulation. Teams with high-quality performance strategies outperformed the rest. The best sustained performance came from teams that had both a high-quality charter and a high-quality strategy.

The lesson is that a charter works best alongside a plan for the work itself. Agreeing how to work together is one half; agreeing how to tackle the task is the other.

A study of project teams from five large companies points the same way (Ericksen and Dyer, 2004). The three high-performing teams mobilised relatively quickly, and broadly rather than narrowly. They also held participatory launch meetings rather than scripted ones. The three low performers slid into confusion and inactivity from which they never recovered.

Both studies are small, and neither looked at senior teams. Still, they fit a wider pattern in team research. Hackman and Wageman (2005) argue that coaching has most effect at particular times in a team's work. Hackman named the launch, the midpoint and the end (Coutu, 2009).

A rule of thumb

A charter is a plan for how you work together. Pair it with a plan for the work itself: the priorities, who leads each one and how you will track them.

How do you write a team charter together?

Write it with the whole team, in one or two sessions. A charter the leader writes alone tells members what to do. A charter they write together is one they have agreed to.

1. **Draft alone**
   Before the session, each member answers the questions in the table above in a few lines.
2. **Compare**
   Put the drafts side by side. Mark where answers differ, especially on purpose, team tasks and membership.
3. **Discuss the differences**
   Start with purpose, then team tasks and decision rights. Leave working agreements until those are settled.
4. **Agree and write**
   One person holds the pen and drafts a single page during the session or straight after it.
5. **Test it**
   Use it for the next two or three meetings, then adjust what does not work.

Drafting alone matters. In brainstorming experiments, people who worked alone and pooled their ideas produced more than groups talking together. The main cause was waiting for a turn to speak (Diehl and Stroebe, 1987). Private drafts also put every member's view on the table before the discussion starts.

The leader still has a distinct role. Hackman noted that setting a team's direction involves authority, and the responsibility can fall to the leader (Coutu, 2009). Some parts, such as membership, may be the leader's call. Say which parts are open for discussion before you start.

If the team has not yet agreed what it is for, start there. The article on the purpose of a leadership team sets out the questions to ask.

What does a sample leadership team charter look like?

The outline below is an illustration, not a real team's charter. Replace each line with your team's own words.

SAMPLE **Leadership team charter**

PURPOSE	This team exists to … (two or three sentences on what it must produce together).
TEAM TASKS AND DECISION RIGHTS	We decide: annual priorities and how resources are split between units. We coordinate: initiatives that cross units. We advise: decisions one member owns. We inform: only what everyone needs.
MEMBERSHIP	Core: the leader and the heads of the main units. Extended: named specialists, who join for specific items.
WORKING AGREEMENTS	We read papers before we meet. Each item states the outcome it needs. We disagree in the room, not afterwards. Once we decide, we explain the decision as one team.
SUPPORT	The data we need for each decision, how shared results count in members' goals, and one development session a year.
KEY STAKEHOLDERS	The board, the owners and employee representatives, and when each hears from us.
REVIEW	We review this charter every six months, and whenever a member joins or leaves.

How do you keep a team charter alive?

Use it every time you set an agenda. Before an item goes on, ask whether it belongs to the team and which of the four uses it serves. If it does not belong, send it to a one-to-one, a smaller group or a written update.

For how to turn the charter into a working agenda, with outcomes and time boxes, see leadership team meeting agenda.

Review it at least once or twice a year, and whenever members join or leave. Hackman pointed to the midpoint of a team's work as a moment to review what is working and correct course (Coutu, 2009). For a standing leadership team, a half-yearly review can play a similar role.

Bring it into the room. Read the purpose aloud at the start of a strategy session, or check one working agreement at the end of each meeting. A charter that nobody quotes has stopped working.

What are the most common mistakes with team charters?

Written by the leader alone

Members receive it rather than agree to it. The launch research favours participation over a script (Ericksen and Dyer, 2004).

Too long

A charter nobody can recall cannot guide a meeting. Keep it to one page, and cut anything you would never check.

Values instead of decisions

Words such as respect and trust say little about what reaches the agenda. Name issues, decision rights and visible behaviour.

Never revisited

Members change and priorities move. A charter left alone for years describes a team that no longer exists.

What can you do this month?

- Ask each member to write, alone, one sentence on why the team exists. Compare the sentences at your next meeting.
- List the issues that came to the team last quarter, and mark each one: decide, coordinate, advise or inform.
- Ask everyone to name the members of the team. If the lists differ, settle membership first.
- Agree three working agreements you can observe, and check them at the end of the next three meetings.
- Put a review date in the calendar before the session ends.

A question for your team

Which issue took the most time in our meetings this quarter, and did it need all of us? Let each member answer before anyone discusses it.

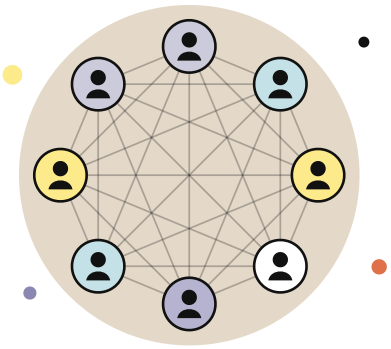
SOURCES

1. Bang, H., & Midelfart, T. N. (2021). Effective management teams and organizational behavior: A research-based model for team development. Routledge.
2. Coutu, D. (2009). Why teams don't work (an interview with J. Richard Hackman). Harvard Business Review, 87(5), 98–105.
3. Diehl, M., & Stroebe, W. (1987). Productivity loss in brainstorming groups: Toward the solution of a riddle. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 53(3), 497–509.
4. Ericksen, J., & Dyer, L. (2004). Right from the start: Exploring the effects of early team events on subsequent project team development and performance. Administrative Science Quarterly, 49(3), 438–471.

5. Feldman, D. C. (1984). The development and enforcement of group norms. Academy of Management Review, 9(1), 47–53.
6. Hackman, J. R. (2002). Leading teams: Setting the stage for great performances. Harvard Business School Press.
7. Hackman, J. R., & Wageman, R. (2005). A theory of team coaching. Academy of Management Review, 30(2), 269–287.
8. Mathieu, J. E., & Rapp, T. L. (2009). Laying the foundation for successful team performance trajectories: The roles of team charters and performance strategies. Journal of Applied Psychology, 94(1), 90–103.
9. Wageman, R. (2020). Four kinds of leadership teams [Video lecture, recorded 2013]. The Business & Management Collection, Henry Stewart Talks.
10. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.

CHAPTER 6

How big should a leadership team be?



As small as the work allows: research on groups finds that coordination gets harder, and members' individual performance can suffer, as a team grows. Richard Hackman, who studied senior teams with colleagues, advised against teams in double digits. The evidence on an exact number is mixed, so decide by the work. Keep the core to people whose work must be integrated, and inform the others another way.

IN SHORT

- Research on groups finds coordination and mutual support harder to sustain as teams grow. People also tend to put in less effort when working collectively. No study gives one right number for a leadership team.
- Richard Hackman's rule of thumb was no double digits. He warned that a team of all the chief executive's direct reports may be worse than no team.
- A meta-analysis found that management teams did slightly better with more members, so size is never the whole story.
- Decide membership by the work: a small core for the decisions that need the whole team, and a wider group that is kept informed.

Why does the size of a leadership team matter?

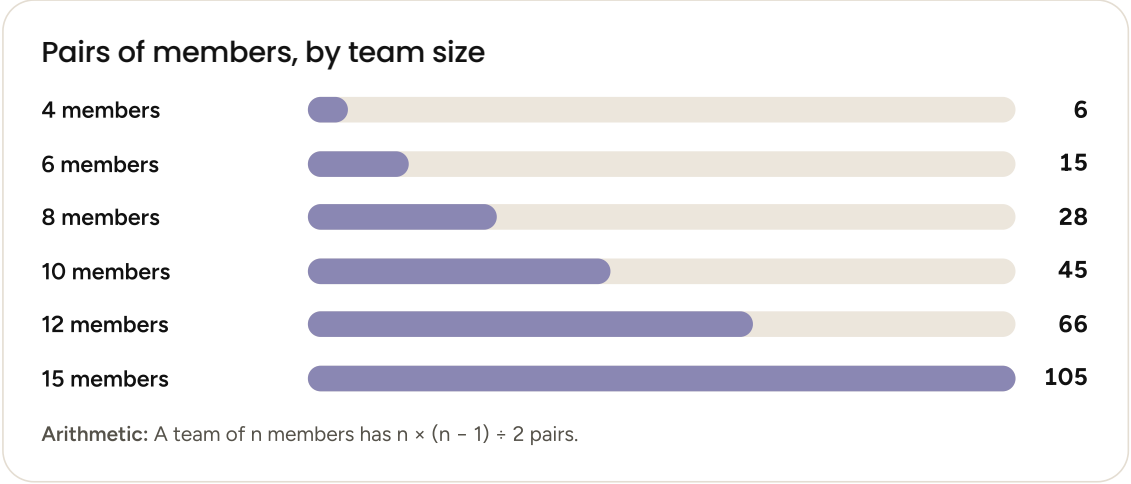
Size is one of the conditions behind leadership team effectiveness, alongside purpose, membership and support. Each person you add brings knowledge, perspective and reach. Each also adds costs, and research on groups has measured several of them.

The oldest idea is process loss. Ivan Steiner argued that what a group actually achieves equals what its members could achieve together, minus the losses of faulty process (Steiner, 1972). The losses he had in mind were mainly problems of coordination and of motivation.

Motivation loss has a large literature of its own. Across 78 studies, Karau and Williams (1993) found that people tend to put in less effort when working collectively than when working alone. This is called social loafing. It appeared across tasks and populations. Its strength depended on conditions such as whether individual contributions could be evaluated and how meaningful the task was.

A third loss concerns support. In a field study of 26 corporate project teams, people in larger teams were rated as performing worse individually (Mueller, 2012). The strongest explanation was what Mueller called relational loss. In larger teams, members felt less sure that colleagues would help and support them when they struggled.

Richard Hackman pointed to the links between members. As a team grows, the number of relationships to manage rises far faster than the headcount (Coutu, 2009). The arithmetic is simple: a team of 8 has 28 pairs of members, and a team of 15 has 105.



Size shows in meetings too. In two survey studies of workplace meetings, larger meetings went with lower involvement from the people attending (Leach et al., 2009). Involvement, in turn, was a key link between how a meeting was designed and how effective people judged it.

What do researchers of senior teams recommend?

Ruth Wageman, Debra Nunes, James Burruss and Richard Hackman studied more than 120 senior teams around the world (Wageman et al., 2008; Coutu, 2009). Getting the right people on the team is one of the conditions their book sets out for a great senior leadership team.

In an interview about that work, Hackman said almost every senior team they studied thought its boundaries were clear. Yet when members were asked to describe their team, fewer than 10 per cent agreed about who was on it (Coutu, 2009).

He saw the chief executive as often responsible. Some leaders fear seeming to exclude anyone; others add people for political reasons. Either way, the result can be a team that does not work. His rule of thumb was no double digits. He warned that a large senior team, such as one of all the chief executive's direct reports, may be worse than none.

Treat that number as what it is: a rule of thumb from decades of study, not a threshold tested in one study. The reasoning behind it, the cost of managing links between members, is the part to hold on to.

Hackman also described a firm where the finance chief was kept off the executive committee because he was unwilling to work towards collective solutions. The chief executive briefed him before and after every meeting, and by Hackman's account the team worked much better (Coutu, 2009). Being off the team did not mean being out of the loop.

Is there an optimal team size?

Not one that the research agrees on. The findings point in different directions, depending on the task and on what is measured.

A meta-analysis of 93 studies looked at how features of team design relate to performance (Stewart, 2006). Project and management teams performed slightly better when they had more members.

An early laboratory study used student groups of two to seven people (Hackman and Vidmar, 1970). Size made little difference to performance, but it strongly affected how members felt. Dissatisfaction rose roughly in step with group size.

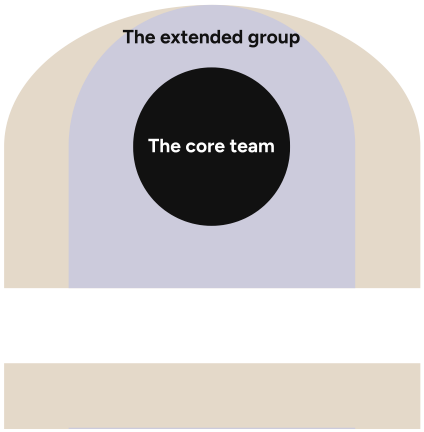
So the useful question is less what number, and more what work. Every member adds knowledge and perspective, and every member adds coordination, effort and support costs. A team that must make joint decisions pays those costs in every meeting, so its core should hold only the people those decisions need.

A rule of thumb

Count the people whose work must be integrated to deliver the team's shared tasks. That is the core. Everyone else needs good information and a way to give input, not a seat at every meeting.

What is a core and an extended leadership team?

One practical answer to the size problem is two circles. It is an arrangement, not a research finding, but it follows from the costs described above.



- **The core team**
  The few people who make the decisions that need the whole organisation in view. They meet often and share accountability for the team's tasks.
- **The extended group**
  Leaders who need the same information and whose views matter. They meet less often, to hear about direction and give input before big decisions.
- **Invited guests**
  People who join for one item, bring their expertise and leave. Their place depends on the agenda, not on their title.

Th[redacted]eetings. The core meets to decide. The extended group meets to inform, consult and align. Mixing the two tends to produce a large meeting that does neither well.

To find the core, start from the purpose of a leadership team: the tasks that only the whole team can do. Then ask who is needed for each of them.

What are the signs your leadership team is too big?

None of these is conclusive on its own. Each is a prompt to look more closely at who is in the room and why.

Sign	What it suggests
Members disagree about who is on the team	The boundaries are unclear. Settle membership before anything else.
Most items concern only one or two units	The agenda carries work that belongs in a smaller forum.
Several members rarely speak in meetings	They may need information rather than a seat at the table.
Decisions are reopened after the meeting	The real decisions are being made in a smaller group outside the room.
Meetings are mostly round-the-table updates	The team works as an information forum, not as a decision group.
Members describe their role as speaking for their unit	Membership follows titles, not the team's shared tasks.

How do you make a leadership team smaller without shutting people out?

Hackman's view was that forming a team calls for hard decisions about membership. Not everyone who wants a seat should have one (Coutu, 2009). Hard decisions go better with clear criteria and a fair process.

1. **Name the team's shared tasks**
   Write down the few things that only this team can do together.
2. **Set membership criteria from those tasks**
   A member is someone whose work those tasks need, not someone with a given title.
3. **Design the extended group**
   Decide what information it receives, how often it meets and how it gives input.
4. **Talk to each person who leaves the core**
   Explain the criteria, what they will still receive and how they can raise an issue.
5. **Review membership once a year**
   When the tasks change, the right members may change too.

Write the criteria into your leadership team charter, so that membership rests on an agreement rather than on status. People accept a boundary more readily when they can see the reason for it.

A question for your team

If this team were formed from scratch today, to do only its shared tasks, who would be on it?

What can you do this month?

- Ask each member to write down, privately, who is on the leadership team. Compare the lists at the next meeting.
- Look at your last three agendas. Count the items that needed every member to reach a good outcome.
- List the decisions the team made together in the past quarter. For each one, note who really needed to take part.
- Try one meeting with only the decision items, and send the information items to the wider group in writing.

A tighter leadership team meeting agenda is a quick test of size. If the team's real work fits a smaller room, the room can shrink.

SOURCES

1. Steiner, I. D. (1972). Group process and productivity. Academic Press.

2. Karau, S. J., & Williams, K. D. (1993). Social loafing: A meta-analytic review and theoretical integration. Journal of Personality and Social Psychology, 65(4), 681–706.
3. Mueller, J. S. (2012). Why individuals in larger teams perform worse. Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes, 117(1), 111–124.
4. Coutu, D. (2009). Why teams don't work (an interview with J. Richard Hackman). Harvard Business Review, 87(5), 98–105.
5. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.
6. Stewart, G. L. (2006). A meta-analytic review of relationships between team design features and team performance. Journal of Management, 32(1), 29–55.
7. Hackman, J. R., & Vidmar, N. (1970). Effects of size and task type on group performance and member reactions. Sociometry, 33(1), 37–54.
8. Leach, D. J., Rogelberg, S. G., Warr, P. B., & Burnfield, J. L. (2009). Perceived meeting effectiveness: The role of design characteristics. Journal of Business and Psychology, 24(1), 65–76.

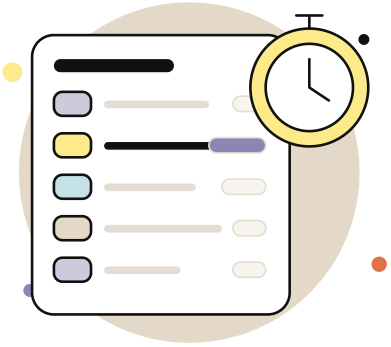
PART 3

Meetings and decisions

Where a leadership team does most of its work together, and how to make that time count.

CHAPTER 7

Leadership team meeting agenda: how to build one that works



A good leadership team agenda lists fewer items and marks each one as information, discussion, decision or follow-up. Each item carries one sentence on the outcome its owner wants, a time box and a pre-read sent in advance. And it carries only issues that need the whole team.

IN SHORT

- Having an agenda is not enough on its own. Research links meeting effectiveness to how the agenda is used.
- Mark every item as information, discussion, decision or follow-up, and write the outcome the owner wants in one sentence.
- In a study of top management groups, clear goals for agenda items went with more focused discussion and better results.
- Send pre-reads before a set deadline, keep operational and strategic issues apart, and bring only issues that need the whole team.
- Close with decisions and actions, with owners and dates, and a short check on whether each item reached its outcome.

Why do leadership team agendas fail?

Most leadership teams have an agenda. An agenda alone, though, does not make a good meeting.

Steven Rogelberg, a researcher of workplace meetings, reports that in his research an agenda alone did not make meetings more effective (Rogelberg, 2019). What matters is how the agenda is built and how it is used.

Survey studies point the same way. In two studies of workplace meetings, agenda use stood out among the features that predicted perceived meeting effectiveness (Leach et al., 2009). A later survey of 367 working adults again linked agenda use to perceived meeting quality (Cohen et al., 2011).

Leadership team agendas also have failure modes of their own:

- **Items without a purpose.** A title such as 'Market update' does not say whether the team is to listen, debate or decide.
- **Too many items.** The agenda cannot be done in the time, so items are rushed or carried over.
- **Operations crowd out strategy.** Urgent operational issues fill the time that longer-term questions need.
- **Issues that do not need the whole team.** Two members work through their problem while the rest wait.

Perlow, Hadley and Eun (2017) argue that standard fixes, such as a clear agenda, are not enough on their own. They suggest the team looks at its meetings together and agrees what to change, rather than each member quietly putting up with them.

What does research on top management meetings show?

Henning Bang and colleagues studied eight top management groups as they handled 56 agenda items, using both self-reports and observers (Bang et al., 2010). Goal clarity and focused communication were both positively related to team effectiveness. Effectiveness here covered task performance, relationship quality and member satisfaction. For how meetings fit with the other drivers, see what makes a leadership team effective.

Part of the effect of clear goals ran through more focused discussion. Speaking up when an item's goal was unclear went with more focus, better task performance and better relationships. Speaking up when a discussion had drifted off track did not help performance, and it went with poorer relationships.

One practical reading is to make the goal clear before the discussion starts, rather than to police focus once it has drifted. A desired outcome written on the agenda does that work in advance.

A study of 92 videotaped team meetings in organisations adds to the picture (Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012). Teams with more problem-solving talk and action planning were more satisfied with their meetings. Better meetings went with higher team productivity. Criticising others and complaining were linked to worse outcomes, and those effects were stronger than the positive ones.

What should each item on the agenda say?

Every item needs a type, a desired outcome, an owner and a time box. Most items also need a pre-read.

EXAMPLE

One agenda item, written out

ITEM	A price change affecting two divisions
TYPE	Decision
DESIRED OUTCOME	We agree whether to change prices next quarter, and how.
OWNER	Commercial director
TIME BOX	30 minutes
PRE-READ	Sent by the deadline, with the question for the team at the top.

Mark the type

The type tells members what the item asks of them. Michael Mankins studied how executive teams use their meeting time (Mankins, 2004). He recommends labelling each item as information, discussion or decision (Mankins and Davis-Peccoud, 2014). A fourth type, follow-up, keeps earlier decisions in view.

Type	What it asks of the team	Example of a desired outcome
Information	Listen, understand and ask questions, with no debate on the substance.	Everyone understands the main points of the quarterly results and has asked their questions.
Discussion	Give views and weigh options, with no decision today.	We know how each unit would be affected before we decide next month.
Decision	Make a choice in the meeting.	We agree which two projects to stop.
Follow-up	Check that earlier decisions are being carried out.	Each open action is on track or has a new date.

Write the desired outcome

The desired outcome is one sentence on what the team will have done when the item ends. It turns a topic into a goal, which is what the research on goal clarity points to.

Rogelberg suggests a related move: frame agenda items as questions the meeting must answer (Rogelberg, 2019). If nobody can write a question, he argues, the meeting may not be needed.

A rule of thumb

If the owner cannot write the desired outcome in one sentence, the item is not ready for the meeting.

Name the owner and set a time box

The owner prepares the item, writes the pre-read and leads it in the meeting. The time box is set by what the outcome needs. Rogelberg advises against simply accepting the calendar's default meeting length (Rogelberg, 2019).

When an item overruns, the chair asks the team to choose. Either extend it and drop something else, or park it with a clear next step.

How should pre-reads and deadlines work?

Information is often better sent than presented. Mankins recommends moving information-only items into pre-reading, so that meeting time goes to discussion and decisions (Mankins and Davis-Peccoud, 2014).

A pre-read only works if people have time to read it. One that arrives late tends to be presented in the meeting instead, which uses up the time it was meant to save.

- Set a deadline for papers, and keep to it.
- Keep each pre-read short, and put the question for the team at the top.
- Say whether members should come with a view, a decision or questions.
- If the papers miss the deadline, move the item to the next meeting.

Agree these rules in your leadership team charter. The chair is then holding the team to a shared agreement, not to a personal preference.

Does this item need the whole leadership team?

The most useful filter is a short test before an item goes on the agenda. It keeps out issues that belong with one or two members, or with a single unit. The test follows from the purpose of a leadership team: the work only the whole team can do.

1. Does the issue affect several units, or the organisation as a whole?
2. Does it need knowledge or authority that only the full team holds?
3. Will the team's decision or advice change what happens next?
4. Is a meeting the best way to handle it, rather than a paper, a call or a smaller group?

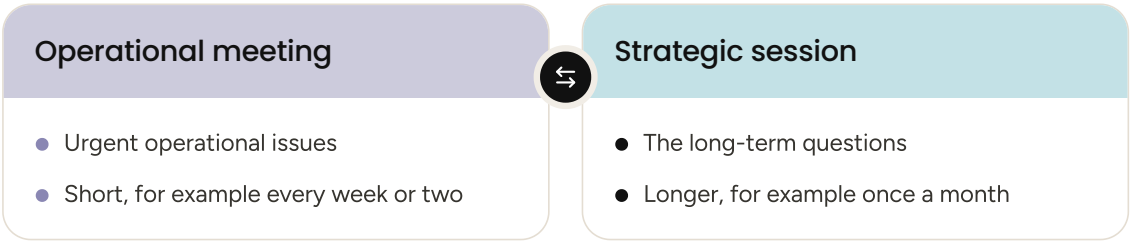
If the answer to the first three is no, the item belongs elsewhere. The same test, applied to people rather than items, is a good way to think about leadership team size.

Should strategic and operational issues share a meeting?

Often they should not. Mankins (2004) reported that the senior executives of a typical company spent only about three hours a month in meetings on strategy.

His first recommendation was to deal with operations and strategy in separate meetings (Mankins and Davis-Peccoud, 2014). The aim is that urgent operational issues cannot crowd out the long-term questions.

For example, a leadership team might hold a short operational meeting every week or two, and a longer strategic session every month. The rhythm is yours to choose. The principle is that each meeting has one kind of work.



Source: Mankins and Davis-Peccoud (2014)

What topics belong on a leadership team agenda?

These are the kinds of topic that usually pass the whole-team test:

- **Direction and priorities:** where the organisation is going, what it will stop doing and how resources are divided.
- **Cross-unit decisions:** choices that move costs or benefits between units, or that no single unit can make alone.
- **Follow-up of decisions:** whether what the team decided is being carried out, and what is in the way.
- **People and leadership:** succession, key appointments, culture and how leaders across the organisation develop.
- **Risks:** the few risks that could change the organisation's course, and who is watching each one.
- **The team itself:** now and then, how the team is working and what it should change.

Discussion and decision items are where disagreement belongs. How to keep it about the work is the subject of task conflict and relationship conflict.

What does a good leadership team agenda look like?

The table below is an illustrative example, not a real team's agenda. It shows a meeting of just under two hours, with a type, a desired outcome, an owner and a time box for

every item.

An example agenda

Item	Type	Desired outcome	Owner and time
Opening: the purpose of this meeting	Information	Everyone knows what the meeting must achieve.	Chief executive, 5 min
Decisions from the last meeting	Follow-up	Each open action is on track or has a new date and owner.	Chair, 10 min
Quarterly results against plan, with a pre-read	Information	Everyone understands the main deviations and has asked their questions.	Finance director, 10 min
A price change affecting two divisions	Decision	We agree whether to change prices next quarter, and how.	Commercial director, 30 min
Succession for critical roles	Discussion	We agree which roles are most exposed and what we need to know before deciding.	HR director, 25 min
Dependence on a single supplier	Discussion	We understand the main options and who will work them up for next month.	Operations director, 20 min
Close: decisions, actions and a short check	Follow-up	Decisions and actions have owners and dates, and we know which items reached their outcome.	Chair, 10 min

The example agenda, minute by minute

EXAMPLE



Information 15 min · **Follow-up** 20 min · **Discussion** 45 min · **Decision** 30 min

110 minutes in all

Opening: the purpose of this meeting	**5 min**
Decisions from the last meeting	**10 min**
Quarterly results against plan	**10 min**
A price change affecting two divisions	**30 min**
Succession for critical roles	**25 min**
Dependence on a single supplier	**20 min**
Close: decisions, actions and a short check	**10 min**

An example to show the idea, not data from a real team.

Notice what is not there: no round of updates from each unit. Those go out in writing, and members raise them in the meeting only when they need the whole team.

How should a leadership team meeting end?

The last ten minutes decide whether the meeting changes anything. Use them for two things.

1. **Record decisions and actions.** Read back each decision, and each action with an owner and a date. Mankins recommends a decision log that the team reviews at its next meeting (Mankins and Davis-Peccoud, 2014).
2. **Check the outcomes.** Go through the items and ask whether each one reached its desired outcome. Where one did not, agree what happens next.

In the study of videotaped meetings, action planning was among the behaviours that went with more satisfying meetings (Kauffeld and Lehmann-Willenbrock, 2012). A clear close gives action planning a fixed place.

Now and then, add one question about the meeting itself: what should we do differently next time? Perlow, Hadley and Eun (2017) recommend regular group check-ins like this, weekly at first, when a team sets out to change how it meets.

A question for your team

Looking at our last meeting, which items reached the outcome we wanted, and which ones did not need all of us?

What can you do this month?

- Rewrite the next agenda with a type and a one-sentence desired outcome for every item.
- Run the whole-team test on every proposed item, and move at least one item that fails it.
- Set a deadline for pre-reads, and hold to it at least once.
- Move one strategic topic out of the regular meeting into a session of its own, and compare the discussion.
- End the next meeting with the outcome check, and note how many items reached their goal.

SOURCES

1. Rogelberg, S. G. (2019). The surprising science of meetings: How you can lead your team to peak performance. Oxford University Press.
2. Leach, D. J., Rogelberg, S. G., Warr, P. B., & Burnfield, J. L. (2009). Perceived meeting effectiveness: The role of design characteristics. Journal of Business and Psychology, 24(1), 65–76.
3. Cohen, M. A., Rogelberg, S. G., Allen, J. A., & Luong, A. (2011). Meeting design characteristics and attendee perceptions of staff/team meeting quality. Group Dynamics: Theory, Research, and Practice, 15(1), 90–104.
4. Bang, H., Fuglesang, S. L., Ovesen, M. R., & Eilertsen, D. E. (2010). Effectiveness in top management group meetings: The role of goal clarity, focused communication, and learning behavior. Scandinavian Journal of Psychology, 51(3), 253–261.
5. Kauffeld, S., & Lehmann-Willenbrock, N. (2012). Meetings matter: Effects of team meetings on team and organizational success. Small Group Research, 43(2), 130–158.
6. Mankins, M. C. (2004). Stop wasting valuable time. Harvard Business Review, 82(9), 58–65.
7. Mankins, M., & Davis-Peccoud, J. (2014). Decision insights: Stop wasting valuable time! Bain & Company.
8. Perlow, L. A., Hadley, C. N., & Eun, E. (2017). Stop the meeting madness. Harvard Business Review, 95(4), 62–69.

PART 4

How the team works together

Psychological safety, trust and conflict: the states that make it possible to speak up and decide well.

CHAPTER 8

Psychological safety in leadership teams



Psychological safety is a team's shared belief that it is safe to take interpersonal risks: to ask, disagree or admit a mistake. In a leadership team it is both rarer and more consequential. Members carry status, compete for resources and answer for their own units, so silence can feel like the safer choice. Members watch the leader's reactions closely, which gives the leader a strong lever to change that.

IN SHORT

- Psychological safety is a shared confidence that no one in the team will be shamed, rejected or punished for speaking up (Edmondson, 1999).
- It is not comfort and not lower standards. The aim is high safety and high standards together.
- It is harder at the top, where members hold status, compete for resources and speak for their own units.
- The leader's reactions carry extra weight: invite views before giving yours, admit what you do not know and thank the bearer of bad news.
- Watch who speaks, how early bad news arrives and whether mistakes are discussed in the room.

What is psychological safety?

Amy Edmondson introduced team psychological safety in a study of 51 work teams in a manufacturing company. She defined it as a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk taking (Edmondson, 1999). The belief is usually tacit. Nobody states it, but everyone acts on it.

In that study, safer teams showed more learning behaviour: asking questions, seeking feedback, experimenting, reflecting on results and discussing errors. Learning behaviour, in turn, linked safety to the team's performance (Edmondson, 1999). The idea itself is older. Organisational researchers first explored it in the 1960s, and interest revived from the 1990s (Edmondson and Lei, 2014).

Psychological safety is close to trust, but it is not the same thing. Edmondson described it as going beyond trust, to a climate of trust and mutual respect where people feel free to be

themselves (Edmondson, 1999). Trust is an expectation about what another person will do. Safety is a shared belief about how the group treats someone who takes a risk. If trust is your concern, read how to build trust in a leadership team.

Does psychological safety mean being nice or lowering standards?

No. It is not a cosy team. Edmondson wrote that the term means neither letting anything go nor a constant positive mood. It is also different from cohesion, since close-knit groups can become less willing to challenge each other, as in groupthink (Edmondson, 1999).

It is not lower standards either. Edmondson treats psychological safety and performance standards as two separate dimensions, and a team needs both (Edmondson, 2018). Safety without standards gives a comfortable team that does not stretch. Standards without safety give an anxious team, where people keep problems to themselves.



Source: Edmondson (2018)

Edmondson and Kerrissey (2025) list the common misreadings. Psychological safety does not mean avoiding argument, backing every idea or escaping accountability for results. Debate can still be uncomfortable. What changes is that candour is expected and not punished.

A rule of thumb

Psychological safety is about what happens to the person who speaks, not about how pleasant the meeting feels. A team can argue hard and still be safe.

Why does psychological safety matter?

The research base is now large. A major review links psychological safety to voice, teamwork, team learning and organisational learning (Edmondson and Lei, 2014). One meta-analysis drew on 136 independent samples, with more than 22,000 people and nearly 5,000 groups

(Frazier et al., 2017). It examined what predicts psychological safety. It also tested whether safety adds to task performance beyond related factors, such as good relations with the leader.

51

work teams in the study that introduced team psychological safety

Source: Edmondson (1999)

22,000+

people in a meta-analysis of 136 samples and nearly 5,000 groups

Source: Frazier et al. (2017)

117

project teams, where debate about the work went with better performance when safety was high

Source: Bradley et al. (2012)

It also shapes what disagreement does. In 117 project teams, disagreement about the work went with better performance where psychological safety was high (Bradley et al., 2012). That matters for any team whose job is to argue its way to good decisions. For more, see task conflict and relationship conflict.

Google's research on its own teams ranked psychological safety first among five dynamics of effective teams (re:Work, 2015). That work covered one company's teams, not leadership teams in particular. Much of the wider evidence is also correlational. It shows what goes together, which is not the same as proving cause. For how safety fits with a team's set-up and meetings, see leadership team effectiveness.

Why is psychological safety harder in a leadership team?

You might expect it to come easily at the top. Members are senior, experienced and used to being heard. Yet several features of a leadership team work against it.

Status and hierarchy

In 23 neonatal intensive care units, staff with higher professional status felt safer. Inclusive leaders narrowed that gap (Nembhard and Edmondson, 2006). In a leadership team, the gap between the chief executive and the rest is wide.

Two roles at once

Each member leads a unit and sits on the team. Top team members can hold different information and interests. A theoretical model argues that this divergence hurts decisions unless the process is managed (Edmondson, Roberto and Watkins, 2003).

Unspoken rules

Across four studies, people held taken-for-granted beliefs about when speaking up is risky. These beliefs helped explain silence, even on ideas meant to help the organisation (Detert and Edmondson, 2011).

All eyes on the leader

Members watch the leader's behaviour especially closely. Supportive, non-defensive responses signal that the team is safe, while punitive ones teach silence (Edmondson, 1999).

Competition for budget and people adds to this. Admitting a problem in your own unit can feel like handing a colleague an argument. One symptom to look for is a polite meeting, followed by the real debate in pairs afterwards.

What can the leader of a leadership team do?

Psychological safety is built in the group through many small interactions, not by policy (Edmondson and Kerrissey, 2025). These five practices draw on the research above.

1. **Frame the work as needing everyone.** Talk about the goal, and why each member's view is needed to reach it, more than about psychological safety itself (Edmondson and Kerrissey, 2025).
2. **Acknowledge your own fallibility.** Say what you do not know, and ask whether you are missing something. Leaders who take such risks themselves show that the risk is not punished (Edmondson, 1999).
3. **Ask genuine questions.** Inclusive leaders invite and appreciate others' contributions, in words and in deeds (Nembhard and Edmondson, 2006). Ask questions you do not know the answer to, and ask quieter members by name.
4. **Respond productively to bad news.** Thank the messenger, then ask what happened and what is needed. In a restaurant chain, managers' openness related to employees speaking up more consistently than transformational leadership did (Detert and Burris, 2007). The link ran through employees' sense of safety.
5. **Invite dissent before you state your view.** Members watch the leader closely, so your view stated first can end a discussion before it starts. Ask each member for theirs, and for the strongest case against the leading option.

None of this means agreeing with everyone. You can listen fully, decide against a view and still hold people to account for results (Edmondson and Kerrissey, 2025).

Nor is it the leader's job alone. Edmondson and Kerrissey (2025) argue that it need not start with top leadership, and that any group can build it. In a leadership team, members can practise the same habits with one another: asking, listening and thanking the person who raises a problem.

How can you tell whether your leadership team has it?

Edmondson measured psychological safety with seven survey statements. In substance, they ask whether mistakes are held against people, whether hard issues can be raised and whether taking a risk is safe. Others ask whether people are rejected for being different, whether help is easy to ask for and whether skills are valued (Edmondson, 1999).

You can also watch for signals in your own meetings. The table gives examples. They are illustrations to look for, not a test.

Signal	Lower safety might look like	Higher safety might look like
Who speaks	The same two or three voices, with others speaking only when asked	Most members contribute, including on issues outside their own unit
Bad news	It arrives late, after the problem has grown, or through someone else	It arrives early, from the person closest to it
Mistakes	Discussed in the corridor, or not at all	Discussed in the room, with a question about what to learn
Disagreement	Nods in the meeting, objections afterwards	Objections voiced in the meeting, about the issue
Questions to the leader	Rare, and mostly about detail	Frequent, including challenges to the leader's view

An anonymous survey can add what observation misses. In a small team, protect anonymity with care, or the survey will repeat the silence it is meant to measure. For methods and pitfalls, see how to assess a leadership team.

What can you do this month?

A question for your team

What is one thing we know about the business that we have not yet said in this room? Give everyone a minute to write an answer, then hear each one before you respond.

- **In your next meeting,** hold back your view on one decision until every member has given theirs.
- **When bad news arrives,** thank the person first. Ask what they need before you ask what went wrong.
- **Name one of your own mistakes** from the past quarter, and what you learnt from it.
- **End each meeting with a two-minute review.** Ask what the team avoided saying today, and why.
- **Put the hardest item early** in your leadership team meeting agenda, while people still have the energy to argue it well.

After a month, compare the signals in the table with what you saw before. Then ask the team what has changed, and listen to who answers.

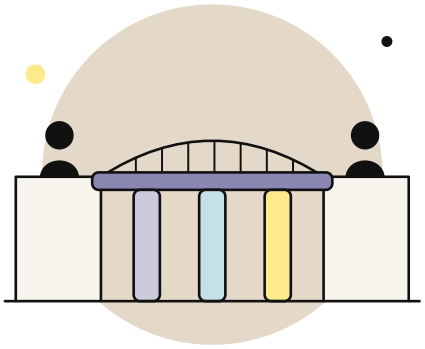
SOURCES

1. Edmondson, A. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383.

2. Edmondson, A. C., & Lei, Z. (2014). Psychological safety: The history, renaissance, and future of an interpersonal construct. Annual Review of Organizational Psychology and Organizational Behavior, 1, 23–43.
3. Frazier, M. L., Fainshmidt, S., Klinger, R. L., Pezeshkan, A., & Vracheva, V. (2017). Psychological safety: A meta-analytic review and extension. Personnel Psychology, 70(1), 113–165.
4. Nembhard, I. M., & Edmondson, A. C. (2006). Making it safe: The effects of leader inclusiveness and professional status on psychological safety and improvement efforts in health care teams. Journal of Organizational Behavior, 27(7), 941–966.
5. Detert, J. R., & Burris, E. R. (2007). Leadership behavior and employee voice: Is the door really open? Academy of Management Journal, 50(4), 869–884.
6. Detert, J. R., & Edmondson, A. C. (2011). Implicit voice theories: Taken-for-granted rules of self-censorship at work. Academy of Management Journal, 54(3), 461–488.
7. Edmondson, A. C., Roberto, M. A., & Watkins, M. D. (2003). A dynamic model of top management team effectiveness: Managing unstructured task streams. The Leadership Quarterly, 14(3), 297–325.
8. Bradley, B. H., Postlethwaite, B. E., Klotz, A. C., Hamdani, M. R., & Brown, K. G. (2012). Reaping the benefits of task conflict in teams: The critical role of team psychological safety climate. Journal of Applied Psychology, 97(1), 151–158.
9. Edmondson, A. C. (2018). The fearless organization: Creating psychological safety in the workplace for learning, innovation, and growth. Wiley.
10. Edmondson, A. C., & Kerrissey, M. J. (2025). What people get wrong about psychological safety. Harvard Business Review, May–June 2025.
11. re:Work Editorial Team (2015). Understand team effectiveness. Google re:Work.

CHAPTER 9

How do you build trust in a leadership team?



Trust in a leadership team grows when members see each other's competence, goodwill and integrity, mostly through small, repeated acts. Doing what you said, sharing the information others need and admitting your mistakes all count. When trust is broken, address the breach directly, and match your response to what went wrong.

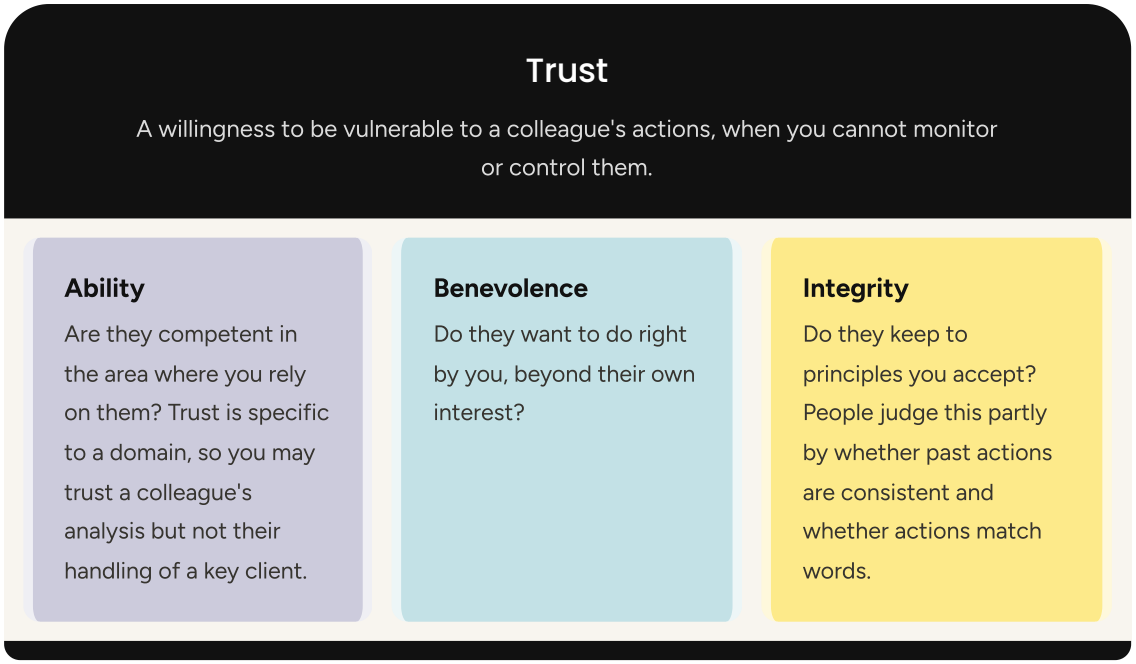
IN SHORT

- Colleagues trust each other when they judge them able, well-meaning and principled.
- Across more than a hundred studies, trust within a team goes with better team performance, especially where the work is interdependent.
- In a study of top teams, debate about the work was less tied to personal friction where trust was high.
- Trust grows from follow-through, shared information, admitted mistakes and fair decisions, not from asking for it.
- After a failure of competence, apologise. Tell the truth: in experiments, apology repaired more trust than denial when later evidence showed guilt.

What is trust in a leadership team?

Researchers define trust as a willingness to be vulnerable to another person's actions, when you cannot monitor or control them (Mayer et al., 1995). In a leadership team, that means relying on a colleague's judgement, figures or promises without checking them yourself.

Mayer et al. (1995) argued that this willingness rests on three judgements about the other person:



Source: Mayer et al. (1995)

McAllister (1995) drew a second distinction, in a field study of 194 managers and professionals. **Cognition-based trust** rests on beliefs about a colleague's reliability and dependability. **Affect-based trust** rests on care and concern that runs both ways.

In his data, managers felt more affect-based trust in peers who showed care beyond their role, and in peers they met often. Cognition-based trust was strongly related to affect-based trust, and he argued that some reliability has to come first (McAllister, 1995).

Cognition-based trust

- Rests on beliefs about a colleague's reliability and dependability
- Some of it has to come first, in McAllister's argument

Affect-based trust

- Rests on care and concern that runs both ways
- Was greater with peers who showed care beyond their role, and with peers met often

Source: McAllister (1995)

Basis of trust	What colleagues look for	What builds it in a leadership team
Ability	Competence in the area where they rely on you	Doing your part of the shared work well, and saying where you are not the expert
Benevolence	That you want them to succeed, not only yourself	Sharing information early, and helping beyond your own remit
Integrity	Principles they accept, and words matched by actions	Keeping commitments, and telling the same story in every room

Why does trust matter in a leadership team?

Across 112 studies covering 7,763 teams, trust within a team was positively related to team performance (De Jong et al., 2016). The link held for both cognitive and affective trust, and after accounting for trust in the leader and past performance.

It mattered more where members depended on each other's work, and less where they could work alone (De Jong et al., 2016). These are correlations, so they do not show which comes first. A leadership team that shares real decisions is the kind of team where trust should matter most.

Trust also shapes how disagreement plays out. In a study of 70 top management teams, trust weakened the link between task conflict and relationship conflict (Simons and Peterson, 2000).

Their reading was that people in low-trust teams tend to take a challenge to their idea as an attack on themselves. With trust, a team can get the benefits of debate with less of the cost. For more, see task conflict and relationship conflict.

7,763

teams in 112 studies, where trust went with team performance

Source: De Jong et al. (2016)

72

studies linking information sharing with performance, cohesion and satisfaction with decisions

Source: Mesmer-Magnus and DeChurch (2009)

70

top management teams, where trust weakened the link from task to relationship conflict

Source: Simons and Peterson (2000)

Trust is also the base of Lencioni's popular model of team problems (Lencioni, 2002). The research on that model is reviewed in five dysfunctions of a team.

Why is trust harder at the top?

Members of a leadership team each run their own part of the organisation. Senior executives often focus more on their own roles than on the top team's shared work (Wageman et al., 2008).

That leaves colleagues few chances to see each other's ability and goodwill at close range. Affect-based trust went with frequent contact (McAllister, 1995), and a team that meets once a month has little of it. So trust at the top has to be built on purpose, in the meetings and the work the team does share. Trust is one part of a high-performing leadership team; its set-up and meetings are others.

Is trust the same as psychological safety?

No, though they overlap. Edmondson (1999) defined psychological safety as a shared belief that the team is safe for interpersonal risk-taking. She described it as involving trust but going further, to a climate of trust and mutual respect where people can be themselves.

A practical way to hold the difference follows from those definitions. Trust is your judgement of a particular colleague: will they act in my interest? Psychological safety is the team's shared sense of how it treats someone who speaks up.

You need both. Edmondson (1999) suggested that trust may help a team build psychological safety. The companion article covers the second: psychological safety in leadership teams.

What builds trust in a leadership team?

Trust rests on what colleagues see each other do, so it grows mainly through ordinary work. Four kinds of act give colleagues the evidence the research describes.

Follow through on what you said

Integrity is judged partly by whether actions match words and stay consistent over time (Mayer et al., 1995). Each kept commitment adds evidence, and each quietly dropped one takes some away. Say what you will do and by when, and say so early when it slips.

Share the information others need

Across 72 studies, information sharing was positively related to team performance, cohesion and satisfaction with decisions (Mesmer-Magnus and DeChurch, 2009). In the terms of Mayer et al. (1995), sharing is also evidence of benevolence: you are helping a colleague succeed.

Admit your mistakes and limits

Admitting an error makes you vulnerable to how colleagues respond. In the research definition, that willingness is trust itself (Mayer et al., 1995). So admitting a mistake is an act of trust, not only a way to earn it. If you lead the team, go first.

Make decisions in a way people see as fair

Korsgaard et al. (1995) ran an experiment with intact management teams. When members' input was considered and they had some influence, they saw the process as fairer.

That went with more trust in the leader, more attachment to the team and stronger commitment to the decision (Korsgaard et al., 1995). Before you close an item, say what you heard and how it shaped the decision.

A rule of thumb

Trust is built in the work, one kept promise at a time. If a member cannot point to something a colleague did that earned their trust, talk will not supply it.

How do you repair trust after a breach?

Breaches happen in any team under pressure. For example, a forecast is missed, a decision is taken without a colleague who owned the area, or a promise is broken.

Kim et al. (2004) ran two studies of responses to an alleged violation of trust. Trust recovered more after an apology when the issue was competence. When the issue was integrity, a denial repaired more than an apology.

But the facts mattered. Apologising worked better when later evidence showed guilt, and denying worked better when later evidence showed innocence (Kim et al., 2004). For a leadership team, the lesson is to tell the truth, not to pick a tactic.

1. **Name it soon**
   Raise it in the meeting or with the person, before it travels into side conversations.
2. **Say what happened and what it cost**
   Say it plainly, without explaining it away.
3. **Match the repair to the breach**
   For a failure of competence, apologise and show what you will do differently. When your integrity is in question, set out the facts plainly.
4. **Then show it**
   Repaired trust rests on the same evidence as new trust: consistent action over the following weeks.

What should you avoid when building trust?

- **Exercises that replace the work.** Time together can help, since frequent contact went with affect-based trust (McAllister, 1995). But an off-site exercise shows little about ability or follow-through, which colleagues judge from the work.
- **Asking for trust.** Saying "trust me" adds no evidence. Colleagues decide from what they observe, so show reliability instead (Mayer et al., 1995).
- **Treating trust as openness alone.** Personal disclosure without delivery wears thin. Ability and integrity count too (Mayer et al., 1995).

- **Holding back information.** Keeping a colleague in the dark, even with good intentions, can read as a lack of goodwill.

What can you do this month?

1. **Make commitments visible.** End each meeting by reading back who will do what by when. Open the next one by checking.
2. **Ask for one piece of information.** Have each member name the one thing from a colleague that would most help their work, and agree how it will flow.
3. **Go first on a mistake.** Share one call you got wrong this quarter and what you learned from it.
4. **Close decisions fairly.** Before you decide, summarise the views you heard and say how they shaped the outcome.
5. **Repair one open breach.** If something is unresolved between members, address it this month with the people involved.

A question for your team

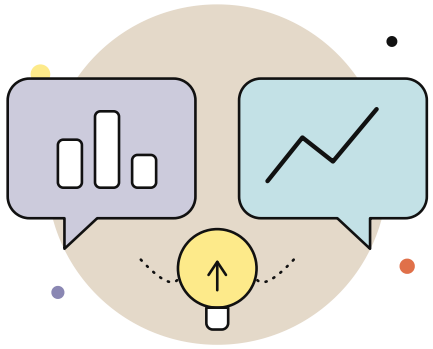
When did someone in this team last do something that made you trust them more? What exactly did they do?

SOURCES

1. Mayer, R. C., Davis, J. H., & Schoorman, F. D. (1995). An integrative model of organizational trust. Academy of Management Review, 20(3), 709–734.
2. McAllister, D. J. (1995). Affect- and cognition-based trust as foundations for interpersonal cooperation in organizations. Academy of Management Journal, 38(1), 24–59.
3. De Jong, B. A., Dirks, K. T., & Gillespie, N. (2016). Trust and team performance: A meta-analysis of main effects, moderators, and covariates. Journal of Applied Psychology, 101(8), 1134–1150.
4. Simons, T. L., & Peterson, R. S. (2000). Task conflict and relationship conflict in top management teams: The pivotal role of intragroup trust. Journal of Applied Psychology, 85(1), 102–111.
5. Edmondson, A. (1999). Psychological safety and learning behavior in work teams. Administrative Science Quarterly, 44(2), 350–383.
6. Mesmer-Magnus, J. R., & DeChurch, L. A. (2009). Information sharing and team performance: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 94(2), 535–546.
7. Korsgaard, M. A., Schweiger, D. M., & Sapienza, H. J. (1995). Building commitment, attachment, and trust in strategic decision-making teams: The role of procedural justice. Academy of Management Journal, 38(1), 60–84.
8. Kim, P. H., Ferrin, D. L., Cooper, C. D., & Dirks, K. T. (2004). Removing the shadow of suspicion: The effects of apology versus denial for repairing competence- versus integrity-based trust violations. Journal of Applied Psychology, 89(1), 104–118.
9. Lencioni, P. (2002). The five dysfunctions of a team: A leadership fable. Jossey-Bass.
10. Wageman, R., Nunes, D. A., Burruss, J. A., & Hackman, J. R. (2008). Senior leadership teams: What it takes to make them great. Harvard Business School Press.

CHAPTER 10

Task conflict and relationship conflict: when disagreement helps



Disagreement about the work, task conflict, can improve a leadership team's decisions when trust and safety are high and debate stays on ideas. Personal friction, relationship conflict, consistently goes with worse performance and satisfaction. So the aim is not less conflict, but conflict about the right things.

IN SHORT

- Task conflict is disagreement about the work. Relationship conflict is personal friction (Jehn, 1995).
- Across meta-analyses, relationship conflict goes with lower performance and satisfaction.
- Task conflict is neither reliably good nor reliably bad. It looks more useful in top management teams and when it stays apart from personal friction.
- Where trust is high, debate about ideas is less tied to personal friction. Where psychological safety is high, task conflict goes with better performance.
- Structure helps: explore several options, test assumptions and agree how you will decide before the debate starts.

What is the difference between task conflict and relationship conflict?

Karen Jehn studied 105 work groups and management teams and separated two kinds of conflict (Jehn, 1995). Task conflict is disagreement about the content of the work: different views, ideas and opinions. Relationship conflict is a sense of personal incompatibility, with tension, annoyance and animosity between members.

Research on top management teams drew the same line. Allen Amason studied strategic decisions in two samples of top teams (Amason, 1996). He separated cognitive conflict, about the issues, from affective conflict, which is personal. He treats the first as functional and the second as dysfunctional: one tends to help strategic decisions, the other to harm them.

Later research added a third kind, process conflict, about how the work should be done and who does what. Like relationship conflict, it tends to go with worse group outcomes (de Wit, Greer and Jehn, 2012).

Jehn's own results were more nuanced than the labels suggest. Both kinds of conflict went with lower satisfaction and less wish to stay in the group. But on non-routine tasks, disagreement about the work did no harm, and sometimes helped (Jehn, 1995). Most of what a leadership team decides is non-routine.

Question	Task conflict	Relationship conflict
What it is about	The work: facts, options, priorities and how to read them	The people: personal friction, tension and dislike
What it can sound like (examples)	"I read these numbers differently." "What would have to be true for this to work?"	"You always do this." "That is typical of your division."
What it does	Mixed. It can improve decisions when trust is high and it stays apart from personal friction	It goes with lower performance and satisfaction across studies
What to do	Invite it, give it structure and keep it on the issue	Notice it early, raise it in private and repair the relationship

Does task conflict help or harm a leadership team?

The answer has shifted as the evidence has built up. Carsten De Dreu and Laurie Weingart pooled earlier studies in a meta-analysis (De Dreu and Weingart, 2003). Relationship conflict showed strong negative correlations with both team performance and member satisfaction. That much was expected.

The surprise was task conflict. It also correlated negatively with performance and satisfaction, against what textbooks had taught. For both kinds of conflict, the negative link with performance was stronger in complex work, such as decision making. The link for task conflict was weaker where task and relationship conflict were only loosely related (De Dreu and Weingart, 2003).

A larger meta-analysis followed. Frank de Wit, Lindred Greer and Karen Jehn pooled 116 studies covering 8,880 groups (de Wit, Greer and Jehn, 2012). Relationship conflict and process conflict again showed stable negative links with group outcomes. But task conflict showed no strong negative link with performance.

105

work groups and management teams in the study that separated the two kinds of conflict

Source: Jehn (1995)

8,880

groups in 116 studies, where task conflict showed no strong negative link with performance

Source: de Wit et al. (2012)

117

project teams, where task conflict went with better performance when psychological safety was high

Source: Bradley et al. (2012)

Their moderators matter most for a leadership team. Task conflict related more positively to performance in three situations (de Wit, Greer and Jehn, 2012):

- where task conflict and relationship conflict were only weakly related
- in top management teams, compared with other teams
- where performance meant financial results or decision quality, rather than overall performance

Psychological safety shapes the effect too. In 117 project teams, task conflict went with better performance when psychological safety was high (Bradley et al., 2012). For more on that condition, see psychological safety in leadership teams.

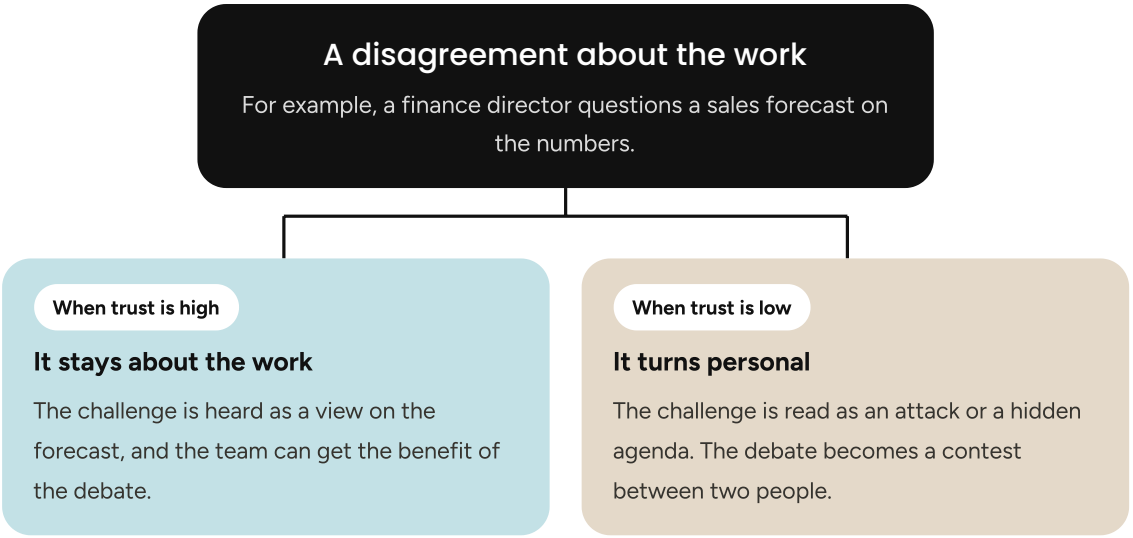
A rule of thumb

Disagreement about the work is worth having while it stays about the work. Once it turns personal, the benefit tends to disappear.

How does task conflict turn into relationship conflict?

In ongoing groups the two kinds tend to travel together. Tony Simons and Randall Peterson studied 70 top management teams to find out why (Simons and Peterson, 2000).

The best-supported explanation was misattribution. When members do not trust each other, they read a disagreement as a personal attack or a hidden agenda. High trust within the team weakened the link between task and relationship conflict. Harsh debating tactics also played a part, though that effect was weak (Simons and Peterson, 2000).



Source: Simons and Peterson (2000)

For example, a finance director may question a sales forecast purely on the numbers. If trust is low, the sales director may hear an attack on the division and answer in kind. The debate about the forecast has become a contest between two people.

A later study found evidence that cognitive conflict can itself feed affective conflict. Behavioural integration, how far a top team shares information, collaborates and decides jointly, appeared to reduce that tendency (Mooney, Holahan and Amason, 2007).

Jehn found something else worth knowing. Norms that encouraged open discussion of conflict went with more relationship conflict, without helping members handle it well (Jehn, 1995). Telling a team to be open is not enough. Openness needs trust and structure around it. If trust is thin, start with how to build trust in a leadership team.

How can a management team have a good fight?

Kathleen Eisenhardt, Jean Kahwajy and L. J. Bourgeois drew on their research into conflict, politics and decision speed in management teams. They described six tactics that high-performing teams used to keep conflict over issues from turning personal (Eisenhardt, Kahwajy and Bourgeois, 1997):

1

More information

Work from more information, not less, so the debate is about facts.

2

Several alternatives

Develop several alternatives, which moves the debate beyond for or against.

3

Common goals

Establish common goals, so members argue about how to succeed together.

4

Humour

Use humour to ease tension.

5

Balanced power

Keep a balanced power structure.

6

No forced consensus

Resolve issues without forcing consensus.

Source: Eisenhardt et al. (1997)

The authors argue that these tactics keep conflict on the issues, make relations collaborative rather than competitive and create a sense of fairness. They also warn that a team without conflict is seldom in agreement. More often it is apathetic and disengaged.

Do devil's advocacy and dialectical inquiry work?

Two structured methods build dissent into a decision. In devil's advocacy, someone tests the facts and assumptions behind a single proposal. In dialectical inquiry, the group debates competing proposals built on different assumptions.

David Schweiger, William Sandberg and James Ragan compared both with plain consensus in a laboratory study (Schweiger, Sandberg and Ragan, 1986). Both methods produced better recommendations and assumptions than consensus. Dialectical inquiry also surfaced better assumptions than devil's advocacy.

There was a cost. Consensus groups were more satisfied, keener to keep working together and more accepting of their decisions. Structured dissent sharpens the thinking, so it needs care for the relationships around it.

What can a leadership team do differently?

1. **Explore before you advocate.** Ask for facts, options and reasoning before anyone argues for a position.
2. **Separate the idea from the person.** Talk about the proposal, not about whose proposal it is. Question assumptions, not motives.

3. **Make options explicit.** Put at least two real alternatives on the table for every major decision, and write down what each one assumes.
4. **Agree how you will decide before you debate.** Say who decides, by when, and what happens if you do not agree. A team can resolve issues without forcing consensus (Eisenhardt, Kahwajy and Bourgeois, 1997).
5. **Assign the challenge.** For big decisions, name a devil's advocate, or ask a pair to build the strongest alternative. Rotate the role so that it does not stick to one person.
6. **Check in on relationships.** After a hard debate, ask how it felt and whether anything needs repair. Catch personal friction while it is still small.

Build these habits into your leadership team meeting agenda. Mark decision items as decisions, and give them enough time for options to be explored before anyone argues for one.

For example, a team weighing a new market might ask one pair to make the case for entering, and another the case for waiting. The team then debates the assumptions behind each case before anyone states a preference. That is a simple form of dialectical inquiry. Conflict about the work is one habit of a high-performing leadership team.

What can you do this month?

A question for your team

Which of our recent disagreements made our decisions better, and which made us worse as a team? Ask each member to name one of each, then talk about the difference.

- **Pick one decision** on the next agenda and ask for two written options before the meeting.
- **Name the decision rule** at the start of that item: who decides, and how.
- **Appoint a challenger** for that item, and thank them afterwards in front of the team.
- **Close the meeting** by asking whether any disagreement felt personal. Follow up one to one if it did.
- **Review one past decision** on which the team disagreed. Ask whether the disagreement improved the decision, and what made it useful or harmful.

Repeat this for a month. If disagreement grows but stays on the work, the team is moving in the right direction.

SOURCES

1. Jehn, K. A. (1995). A multimethod examination of the benefits and detriments of intragroup conflict. Administrative Science Quarterly, 40(2), 256–282.
2. Amason, A. C. (1996). Distinguishing the effects of functional and dysfunctional conflict on strategic decision making: Resolving a paradox for top management teams. Academy of Management Journal, 39(1), 123–148.

3. De Dreu, C. K. W., & Weingart, L. R. (2003). Task versus relationship conflict, team performance, and team member satisfaction: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 88(4), 741–749.
4. de Wit, F. R. C., Greer, L. L., & Jehn, K. A. (2012). The paradox of intragroup conflict: A meta-analysis. Journal of Applied Psychology, 97(2), 360–390.
5. Simons, T. L., & Peterson, R. S. (2000). Task conflict and relationship conflict in top management teams: The pivotal role of intragroup trust. Journal of Applied Psychology, 85(1), 102–111.
6. Mooney, A. C., Holahan, P. J., & Amason, A. C. (2007). Don't take it personally: Exploring cognitive conflict as a mediator of affective conflict. Journal of Management Studies, 44(5), 733–758.
7. Bradley, B. H., Postlethwaite, B. E., Klotz, A. C., Hamdani, M. R., & Brown, K. G. (2012). Reaping the benefits of task conflict in teams: The critical role of team psychological safety climate. Journal of Applied Psychology, 97(1), 151–158.
8. Eisenhardt, K. M., Kahwajy, J. L., & Bourgeois, L. J. (1997). How management teams can have a good fight. Harvard Business Review, 75(4), 77–85.
9. Schweiger, D. M., Sandberg, W. R., & Ragan, J. W. (1986). Group approaches for improving strategic decision making: A comparative analysis of dialectical inquiry, devil's advocacy, and consensus. Academy of Management Journal, 29(1), 51–71.

Where to go next

New articles appear at www.leaderpact.com/articles.

Free templates for a team charter and a meeting agenda are at www.leaderpact.com/templates.

To see how your own team works, the Leadership Team Scan at www.leaderpact.com takes about three minutes and needs no account.